OFFICIAL UNITY GAME JAM 2026 · THEME: LUCKY NUMBER

NaN

ZERO-SUM: OMEN

The World & Art Bible

World · Lore · Lands · Characters · Art Direction · Gameplay · Production
Version 1 · TR 1002 · Living document: the Markdown files in `docs/` are the source of truth.

Contents

1. **The game in one page**
2. **The world**: why numbers matter, history, the villain, the lands, the cast, plot and endings
3. **Lore lexicon**: glossary, idioms, timeline, factions, world rules, naming
4. **The lands**: colour scripts, concept plates, locations guide
5. **Characters**: model pages (silhouette, palette, canon locks) and the character bible
6. **Art direction**: painted world, inked people; lessons from the Cyberpunk 2077 art book
7. **Gameplay**: the game design document
8. **Production**: plan, art status, prompt pack
9. **Appendix**: narrative style guide, AI disclosure

How to use this bible: when two documents disagree, the order of authority is Art Direction (for visuals) → Character Bible (for characters) → World Bible (for story) → GDD (for mechanics).

PART I

The game in one page

What we are making and why it will feel like nothing else.



In a world where every soul's luck floats above its head as a number, a nameless wanderer with no number at all tells the city its lucky number, and becomes the most wanted person alive.

The fantasy

You are NIL, the world's missing luck in human form. Every number in the Tally spins like a slot reel, and you are the only one who can stop them. Travel lands inspired by Japanese, Chinese, Indian, Greek and American myth, gather a party of eight, and break the seals of the machine that flattened every culture's idea of luck into one zero-sum number.

The play

One verb: tap to stop the number. Three heroes strike, their digits drop into the reel, and patterns pay out as full-screen anime cinematics. Depth comes from team synergy (heroes whose lucky digits add to 10, run in sequence, or are all prime), charms from every culture, and wheels you reshape like a deck.

The look

Painted world, inked people. Hand-painted, sunlit, lived-in lands in the spirit of Studio Ghibli's backgrounds; graphic, neon-edged characters and fights in the spirit of *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners*.

The theme

A world that believes luck is zero-sum learns, from a party drawn from every culture, that luck shared isn't.

PART II

The world

Why numbers matter, where they came from, and who wants to freeze them forever.



> *"Every soul a number. Every number a share. The books must balance."* — the Comptroller's catechism, recited at every Dawn Tally

This file is the story source of truth: world, lore, lands, villain, cast, plot and endings. Mechanics live in `GDD.md`; schedule and pipeline in `PRODUCTION_PLAN.md`.

1. The one-paragraph pitch

In **the Tally**, every living soul carries a floating number, its **Omen** (00–99), which is literally its share of the world's luck. Luck is conserved: for one Omen to rise, another must fall. It wasn't always like this. Every people once had its own idea of fate: the Greeks' spun thread, the Indian scribe's ledger of deeds, the Chinese and Japanese underworld books of the dead, the deal struck at an American crossroads at midnight. Then the capital, **Meridian**, built **the Basilica** and bound every one of those ledgers into one machine that gives every soul one number.

NIL wakes in Meridian's slums with no number at all, only a glitching **NaN**. When NIL is made to state a lucky number at a back-alley Naming Rite, the Basilica screams **REMAINDER DETECTED**, and every bounty hunter in the world comes running. To stop the **Final Audit**, which will freeze every fate forever and erase NIL to balance the books, NIL must travel the lands of the Tally, free the ledgers the Basilica stole, gather a party from every culture, and learn the truth: NIL *is* the world's missing luck.

2. Why numbers matter (the rules of the world)

#	LAW	IN THE WORLD	IN THE GAME
1	**Every soul has an Omen** (00–99)	Everyone can see everyone's number floating above their head. It decides loans, jobs, marriages and how dangerous a staircase is for you today.	Omen is HP. It floats over every combatant. No HP bars.
2	**The Zero-Sum Law**	Total luck is constant. Fortune is traded, taxed, inherited and stolen. Luck banks lend it at interest; debt collectors drain it.	Fights are transfers of luck. The Zero-Sum pattern (digits summing to 10) "balances the books" and cancels a move.
3	**Resonance (your lucky number)**	At seven, every child performs the **Naming Rite** and states their lucky number. That digit is how the Basilica reads you and how you channel luck.	Each hero has a resonant digit. Their wheel favours it, and landing it charges their ultimate. The player chooses NIL's.
4	**Settlement**	At 00 you are *Settled*. Misfortune finds you within days, and your luck flows back to the pool.	Defeat = Settled. Enemies are "rounded down", not gored.
5	**Audits**	When fates collide, Omens contest. Trained **Auditors** summon a **Fate Wheel** (the old *Rota Fortunae*, Fortune's wheel, now made of digits) and strike with the digits they stop.	The core verb: every number spins, and you stop it. Combat is called an Audit.

Daily life details to show, not tell. Lifts skip floors 4, 9 and 13. Weddings crowd onto the 8th. Gamblers kiss sevens. Beggars sell "luck-ins" (a point of Omen for a meal). Children compare Omens in the schoolyard. Shopkeepers hang a lemon with seven green chillies over the door, or a horseshoe, or a blue evil-eye bead, or a beckoning cat, depending on the street.

Lucky and unlucky numbers across the Tally (the jam theme, built into the setting)

NUMBER	WHERE IT'S LUCKY / UNLUCKY	WHY (REAL-WORLD BELIEF THE LAND IS INSPIRED BY)
0	Śūnyapura (India-inspired)	Zero as a number was formalised in India; *śūnya* means void and also the place that holds everything
2	Kroton Nova (Greece-inspired)	The only even prime; Pythagoreans treated numbers as divine
3	Celtic quarter of Meridian	Triads, the triskele; "third time lucky"
4	Hyakki (Japan-inspired) and the River Empire (China-inspired), unlucky	四 sounds like 死, death, in both Japanese (*shi*) and Chinese (*sì*/*sǐ*)

NUMBER	WHERE IT'S LUCKY / UNLUCKY	WHY (REAL-WORLD BELIEF THE LAND IS INSPIRED BY)
7	Meridian, Hyakki, the Crossroads	Western lucky seven; Japan's Seven Lucky Gods; "seven come eleven" at the dice table
8	The River Empire, Hyakki	八 *bā* rhymes with 发 *fā* (to prosper); in Japan 八 widens like a fan (*suehirogari*)
9	Hyakki unlucky; River Empire lucky	Japanese *ku* echoes 苦 (suffering); Chinese *jiǔ* echoes 久 (long-lasting)
13	Meridian, the Crossroads, unlucky	Western triskaidekaphobia
17	Kroton Nova, unlucky	In Italian tradition XVII rearranges to VIXI, "I have lived" (i.e. I am dead)
99 / 100	Hyakki	Japanese folklore: objects that reach 100 years gain a soul (*tsukumogami*)
108	Śūnyapura	Sacred count of prayer beads

3. History (the myth told in the intro)

1. **The Noise.** Before numbers, fortune moved like weather. Floods, plague and ruin fell at random.
2. **The Many Ledgers.** Every people learned to keep accounts with fate in its own way: - In **Kroton Nova**, three sisters, the **Moirai**, spin, measure and cut the thread of every life. - In **Śūnyapura**, the scribe **Chitragupta** records every soul's deeds for the lord of death, and the land's mathematicians gave the world **zero**. - In **the River Empire**, the underworld's Ten Courts keep the **Book of Life and Death** (生死簿), and a Judge holds the brush that writes in it. - In **Hyakki**, the King of Hell, **Enma**, keeps a ledger of the dead, and objects that live a hundred years wake up with souls. - In **the Crossroads Territory**, a stranger waits where two roads meet at midnight with a black book, and anyone can sign a deal for luck.

None of these ledgers agreed. Luck meant karma in one land, thread in another, a contract in a third. The world was messy, plural and alive. 3. **The Basilica.** Meridian, a young trading capital at the centre of the Tally, sent actuaries to every land. Over three centuries they **copied, bought or seized each ledger** and bound them into one brass engine, **the Basilica**, which recomputes one Omen for every soul at sunrise (**the Dawn Tally**). One number for everyone; one law for luck. Meridian became the capital of the world because it holds the merged Ledger. 4. **The Rounding.** Each Dawn Tally divides luck into whole numbers. The fractions, every soul's tiny remainder, are rounded down and dropped. It has happened every day for three hundred years. Nobody noticed. 5. **The Deficit (now).** For forty years the world's total luck has been leaking. **Noise storms** tear open where the books don't balance: patches of pure chance where numbers scramble and glitch-creatures (**Noiselings**) crawl out. Theologians predict **the Default**, the day the Basilica fails and the Noise returns.

The secret (midpoint reveal, Act III, in Śūnyapura, the land that invented zero): the rounded-down fractions didn't vanish. Three centuries of everyone's lost remainders pooled into a hidden account, and that account became a person. **NIL is the Remainder**, the world's missing luck, embodied. NIL has no Omen because NIL isn't *in* the Ledger. NIL *is what the Ledger owes.*

4. The villain: Comptroller Lucan Thale

Role	Comptroller of Meridian, master of the Basilica
Look	Tall, ageless; immaculate white-and-brass vestments shaped like a clockwork cathedral; a monocle with a turning gear; his Omen frozen at **50** (the perfect median), rendered in steel, not light
Voice	Calm, kind, exhausted. Narrates the intro myth.
Backstory	Born in Meridian's slums. At twelve, a Noise storm took his family and his street in one minute, by pure chance. He became the greatest actuary in history to make sure chance never decides anything again.
His plan: the Final Audit	1) Capture the Remainder (NIL) and settle it back into the Ledger, closing the Deficit. 2) Freeze every Omen forever ("Fixed Fate"): no luck, no loss, no Noise.
Why he's not wrong	He would save the world from the Default.
Why he's wrong	He flattened every culture's meaning of fortune into one number, and now he would freeze it. His plan also erases a person.
Line	*"Thread, karma, contracts, books of the dead: a hundred superstitions, and every one of them let people die at random. I replaced them with arithmetic."*

How he hunts NIL: the Auditors and the Seals. Each land's bound ledger is locked into the Basilica by a **Seal**, and each Seal is guarded by that land's **Auditor**, a local power who made a deal with Thale. Deliver the Remainder, and your people are protected (frozen high) under Fixed Fate. The upper gate of Meridian opens only with **seven Seal Digits**: one from each of the six Auditors, and **the seventh is NIL's own lucky number**, the one the player chose in the intro.

Why the party fights: 1. NIL is hunted: every Auditor wants the bounty. 2. The gate needs the Seal Digits. 3. Each land suffers under its Auditor's deal, and breaking a Seal returns that land's own idea of luck to its people. 4. Each companion comes from one land and has a personal stake there. 5. If the Final Audit happens, NIL is erased and fate is frozen.

5. The lands: a journey across the world's mythologies

The Tally is a ring of lands around Meridian's plateau. The upper city is sealed, so to go up, you must go around.

ACT	LAND	INSPIRED BY	ART STYLE	LEDGER HELD THERE	LAW OF THE LAND	AUDITOR (BOSS)	SEAL
Prologue	**Meridian Undercity** (the Remainder Wards)	A cosmopolitan modern capital	Anime cyber-noir: rain, neon, Nixie signage	The Basilica itself	*Debt*: everyone owes luck	**Varro Kade, the Ledgerhound**	1
I	**Hyakki (百鬼), the Isles of a Hundred Demons**	Japanese folklore	*Ukiyo-e* woodblock prints + anime: flat colour, bold outlines, Hokusai waves, torii, lantern light	**Enma's Ledger** of the dead	*The Rule of Shi and Ku*: 4 and 9 are cursed; 7 is blessed	**Tamamo, the Nine-Tailed Auditor**	9
II	**The River Empire**: Bāfā Harbor (八发港) above, the Ten Courts (十殿) below	Chinese folk religion and festival culture	Ink-wash (水墨) for the underworld; *gongbi* (工笔) fine line and gold leaf + neon for the harbor	**The Book of Life and Death** and the Judge's Brush	*The Rule of Interest*: luck compounds	**Chancellor Jin Chan (金蟾), the Golden Toad**	8
III	**Śūnyapura, the City Where Zero Was Born**	Indian mythology, astronomy and mathematics	Indian miniature painting and Pattachitra outlines + anime; monsoon light; giant stone observatory instruments; geometric stepwells	**Chitragupta's Ledger** of deeds (karma)	*The Rule of Karma*: every action is recorded and returns	**Rahu and Ketu, the Eclipse**	0
IV	**Kroton Nova, the Sieve of the Aegean**	Greek mythology and Pythagorean number mysticism	White marble, Aegean blue, mosaic and red-figure-pottery motifs + anime	**The Thread of the Moirai**	*The Rule of Indivisibility*: only primes pass	**Archon Seventeen** of the Pythagorean Synod	2
V	**The Crossroads Territory**	American folklore: frontier tall tales, the blues crossroads legend, immigrant charms, desert neon	Americana: desert sunsets, Route-66 motels, pulp-poster lettering, art-deco casino neon	**The Black Book of the Crossroads**	*The Rule of the House*: the night loops, and every deal has a price	**The House (Octavian Nine, "Mr. Eighty-Nine")**	7
Finale	**Meridian & the Basilica**	—	Brass clockwork cathedral, monochrome + Nixie amber; every land's art style appears on its wall	All of them	*Fixed Fate*	**Comptroller Lucan Thale**	*yours*

Gods are not the villains. Revered figures (Enma, Chitragupta, the Judge of the Ten Courts, the Moirai) appear as **neutral keepers who test the party**, never as enemies to beat up. The Auditors are mortals, folklore tricksters or legendary monsters who made deals with Thale.

Land notes (enemies, set pieces, superstitions)

Meridian Undercity (Prologue) - Enemies: Debt Hounds (cyber-dogs), Collectors (armoured bailiffs), Noiselings (glitch sprites). - Set piece: the Dawn Tally beam sweeping the slums. Its immigrant quarters mix every land's charms on one street. - Superstition: "Don't let a collector read your number twice."

Hyakki (Act I, Japan-inspired) - Enemies: *Kasa-obake* (one-eyed hopping umbrella spirits), *Chōchin-obake* (lantern ghosts), *Kappa* (river imps who lose their strength if they bow), *Oni* enforcers. - Set piece: the **Hyakki Yagyō**, the Night Parade of One Hundred Demons, crossing a red bridge under a full moon; a shrine of the **Seven Lucky Gods**. - Superstitions: no room 4 or 9; daruma dolls get one eye painted when you make a wish and the other when it comes true; the beckoning cat (*maneki-neko*).

The River Empire (Act II, China-inspired) - Bāfā Harbor enemies: Abacus Golems, Debt Junks (armed river boats), Golden Koi spirits (multiply when hit). - Ten Courts enemies: Ox-Head & Horse-Face (牛头马面, twin wardens who must fall in the same round), Hungry Ghosts (eat your coins), Jiangshi. - Set pieces: the Lantern Festival over the Luck Exchange; crossing Naihe Bridge past Meng Po's pavilion of forgetting. - Superstitions: 8 for prosperity; red envelopes; the three-legged money toad; burning joss paper for the dead.

Śūnyapura (Act III, India-inspired) - Enemies: Vetālas (riddling corpse-spirits from the *Vikram and Betaal* tales, who ask a question before they fight), Brass Yantra Guardians (animated observatory instruments), Monsoon Nāgas (serpent spirits of the stepwells). - Set pieces: a city-sized open-air observatory of stone sundials and astrolabes; a vast geometric stepwell descending into the dark; the Hall of Chitragupta with palm-leaf records to the horizon. - Superstitions: a lemon and seven green chillies at the door (*nimbu-mirchi*) against the evil eye; 108 prayer beads; the nine planetary gems (*navaratna*).

Kroton Nova (Act IV, Greece-inspired) - Enemies: Bronze Automata (Talos-like), Harpies, Composite Knights (the Synod's armoured guard), Sirens who sing numbers. - Set pieces: a white island city built as a giant stone sieve, where citizens whose Omens are composite fall through the holes; the cave where the three Moirai spin. - Superstitions: the blue evil-eye bead (*mati*); spitting three times against bad luck; Fortuna's wheel; unlucky 17 among the Italian-descended merchants.

The Crossroads Territory (Act V, America-inspired) - Enemies: the Headless Horseman of the hollow, Card-Sharp Automata, Tumbleweed Golems, a Ghost Train whose cars are Loop Echoes of your party. - Set pieces: a desert crossroads at midnight under one streetlamp; the casino boomtown of Lucky Strike where the same night repeats; a dust storm made of playing cards. - Superstitions: horseshoes over doors (open end up), rabbit's foot, lucky penny, four-leaf clover, "seven come eleven", never count your money at the table.

The Far Lands (expansion plan, not the main game)

Each a short post-launch act with its own ledger, built with cultural consultants: - **Norse North**: the three Norns at the Well of Urðr; nine worlds; runes. - **Kemet** (Egypt): the Weighing of the Heart against Ma'at's feather; 42 assessors. - **The Long Count** (Maya): the other civilisation that invented zero; a base-20 calendar. - **Anansi's Coast** (West Africa, Akan folklore): the spider who bought all the world's stories from the sky god. - **The House of Wisdom** (Islamic Golden Age): al-Khwārizmī, whose name gave us "algorithm"; the *hamsa*.

6. The cast

NIL, the protagonist (the Remainder)

Digit	The player's choice (0–9)
Look	~19, androgynous; silver-white hair with one Nixie-orange streak; amber eyes; a broken holographic **NaN** where an Omen should be; long asymmetric black actuary's coat with brass ledger clasps; a cracked brass **decoder** fused into the right wrist that leaks orange light and floating digits
Personality	Quiet, observant, dry humour; counts things when anxious; fascinated by other people's numbers because they don't have one
Wants → Needs	Wants a number and a normal life. Needs to accept being what everyone lost, and choose what to give back.
Arc	Prologue: hunted nobody → I: learns the Basilica cheats even the dead → II: learns luck is power and debt → III: **learns they are the Remainder** → IV: rejects the idea that some numbers are worth less → V: refuses to loop or hide → Finale: decides the world's future
Growth (the most important in the game)	Each Seal returns a **memory digit**: NIL's fragments are other people's stolen remainders, so each flashback is someone else's lost moment of luck, in the art style of that land. NIL gains a new verb per act (GDD §6).

The roster (8 companions; NIL + 2 in the party)

HERO	DIGIT	FROM	RECRUITED	CLASS	ONE-LINE
Vesper Sette	7	Meridian (raised in the Crossroads casinos)	Prologue	Gunslinger	Ex-croupier who rigged games for the House, until a rigged hand Settled a child
Maeve Triskel	3	Meridian's Celtic immigrant quarter	Prologue (optional)	Charm-smith	Blacksmith's daughter who forges horseshoes and clovers into weapons
Hina of the Ninety-Nine (九十九 雛)	9	Hyakki	Act I	Tsukumogami trickster	An old paper umbrella that woke up with a soul, one year short of a hundred
Ba Jinling (八金铃)	8	River Empire	Act II	Financier	Loan shark who secretly forgives the debts she buys; the Golden Toad's daughter
Bai Si (白四)	4	River Empire (Ten Courts)	Act II	Executioner	The underworld's headsman, who keeps count so no dead soul is lost
Shunya (शून्य)	0	Śūnyapura	Act III	Astronomer	Young mathematician at the great observatory who proves what NIL is
Prima of Kroton	2	Kroton Nova	Act IV	Paladin	The Synod's "even prime" novice, the odd one out
Fibi Leone	Fibonacci	The Crossroads	Act V	Dealer	Card prodigy trapped in the looping night, the only one who remembers

Each hero has a 4-scene **bond arc** (Teahouse/Campfire events) that unlocks their Awakening and affects the true ending. Each also carries a **piece of their land's ledger** that matters at the climax.

Vesper Sette (7)

- **Look:** tall, crooked grin, scar across the lip; black hair with a crimson underlayer in a long braid; crimson long coat over a croupier's waistcoat; wide-brim hat with cards in the band; a revolver with a **seven-chamber cylinder** engraved 1–7.
- **Personality:** dry bravado, gambler's charm, guilt hidden behind jokes. Flips a coin before every decision and ignores the result.
- **Backstory:** dealt for the House in Lucky Strike. Ran when a hand she rigged Settled a twelve-year-old.
- **Bond arc:** teaches NIL to read tells → admits the rigged hand → faces the House → deals an honest hand.
- **Ledger piece:** the House's marked deck, proof the Crossroads deals were rigged.

Maeve Triskel (3)

- **Look:** freckled, red hair in three braids; leather apron over work clothes; **horseshoe-knuckle gauntlets**; a four-leaf-clover pin; a triskele (triple spiral) burned into her forge hammer.
- **Personality:** loud, warm, stubborn, superstitious about everything and proud of it.
- **Backstory:** her family fled to Meridian when their land's luck was "rounded" into the Basilica; her grandmother's charms stopped working that day. She makes new ones.
- **Role:** upgrades charms at the forge (crafting tie-in); comic warmth for the party.
- **Ledger piece:** a horseshoe forged from the first Basilica gear, which can hold one Seal open.

Hina of the Ninety-Nine (九十九 雛, 9)

- **Look:** small girl-shaped spirit; a **red-and-white paper umbrella** she rides and fights with (sometimes it opens a single eye and sticks out its tongue, like a *kasa-obake*); short black bob; furisode kimono patterned with numbers 1–99; geta sandals.
- **Personality:** mischievous, ancient and childish at once; obsessed with turning 100.
- **Backstory:** a 99-year-old umbrella left at Enma's shrine. In Japanese folklore objects that reach 100 years gain a soul (*tsukumogami*). Hina woke up early, at 99, because she was soaked in a century of other people's wishes. The Basilica's Fixed Fate would freeze her at 99 forever: never quite real.
- **Bond arc:** NIL helps her decide she's already real.
- **Ledger piece:** a torn page of Enma's ledger stuck in her umbrella ribs.

Ba Jinling (八金铃, 8)

- **Look:** modern jade-and-gold qipao; eight tiny golden bells in her hair ornaments and anklets; a **folding fan whose ribs are abacus rods**; smoky violet eyes; red lips.
- **Personality:** theatrical, sly, mercenary on the surface, enormous heart.
- **Backstory:** Chancellor Jin Chan's daughter. She left the Luck Exchange when she learned how his fortune was built.
- **Ledger piece:** her father's true account book, the proof of the Exchange's fraud.

Bai Si (白四, 4)

- **Look:** very tall, pale; long white hair bound with black funeral ribbon; white mourning robes (white is the mourning colour in Chinese tradition) inked with 四; a huge guandao-style blade hung with four paper talismans; joss paper swirls around him.
- **Personality:** stoic, formal, honour-bound, unexpectedly tender with children.
- **Backstory:** the Ten Courts' executioner, who counts every Settled soul so none is forgotten.
- **Turn:** NIL's decoder shows him three centuries of rounding: his count has always been short. He joins after Judge Cui's trial.
- **Ledger piece:** the true count of the dead.

Shunya (शून्य, 0)

- **Look:** young woman astronomer; dark hair in a long braid with brass astrolabe pins; indigo-and-saffron layered clothing with mirror-work; a **brass astrolabe** she spins like a weapon; palm-leaf manuscripts tied at her hip; ink-stained fingers.
- **Personality:** brilliant, impatient, joyful about ideas, kind to people who are slow.
- **Backstory:** works at the great observatory where her ancestors formalised zero. She calls 0 "the place that holds everything", not "nothing". She has been tracking the Deficit for years and found that it equals a *person's worth* of luck.
- **Role:** delivers the midpoint reveal to NIL with gentleness and maths.
- **Ledger piece:** the proof: the Remainder equation.

Prima of Kroton (2)

- **Look:** short blonde hair, blue eyes; white-and-gold armour with Greek-key borders; a **giant shield shaped like a sieve**, set with blue glass; a halo of floating glyphs 2-3-5-7.
- **Personality:** earnest, loud, honest to a fault; comic relief who becomes the moral backbone.
- **Backstory:** the Synod calls 2 "the even prime", the odd one out. She has always felt like a mistake in a holy system.
- **Bond arc:** discovers the Sieve is a culling machine; must face her mentor, Archon Seventeen.
- **Ledger piece:** a strand of the Moirai's thread, given to her by Lachesis.

Fibi Leone (Fibonacci)

- **Look:** 18; golden hair in spiral curls; spiral-patterned irises; tailored croupier tailcoat with headset; glowing cards that flow around her in a golden spiral.
- **Personality:** fast-talking, anxious, brilliant; laughs at bad moments.
- **Backstory:** dealer at the House, the only person in Lucky Strike who remembers the night repeats. She has lived it 1,597 times (a Fibonacci number).
- **Twist:** the House loops the night because Fibi dies at dawn. Octavian Nine is her grandfather.
- **Ledger piece:** the last page of the Black Book: her grandfather's own deal.

The Auditors (bosses) and the keepers (trials)

BOSS	LAND	LOOK	MOTIVE	FIGHT (THE RULE)	AFTER DEFEAT
Varro Kade, the Ledgerhound	Meridian	Hulking bailiff, hound-skull mask, debt jars on his belt	Wants the bounty to buy his sister's exemption	**The Collector:** steals your last reel digit into a debt jar; 3 parries shatter it	Spared; returns in Act V
Tamamo, the Nine-Tailed Auditor	Hyakki	A nine-tailed fox in courtly layered robes; foxfire (*kitsunebi*) floating around her; each tail tipped with a glowing digit	Yokai fade when people stop believing in them; Thale promised Fixed Fate would make yokai permanent	**Nine Tails:** each tail is a separate small Omen; foxfire **illusion faces** appear on your wheels (they show one digit and land as another); landing a 9 hurts you (*ku*) unless Hina is in the party	Retreats into legend; leaves Hina a tail-blessing

BOSS	LAND	LOOK	MOTIVE	FIGHT (THE RULE)	AFTER DEFEAT
Chancellor Jin Chan, the Golden Toad	River Empire	Enormous jovial lord robed in gold coins on a three-legged toad throne	His bank will hold the world's frozen luck	**Interest:** his Omen grows every round; he taxes your Jackpots; phase 2 he swallows a hero (land a Pair to free them)	Bankrupted; Jinling takes over the Exchange
Rahu & Ketu, the Eclipse	Śūnyapura	Rahu: a vast severed head with a crown, devouring light; Ketu: a headless serpent body with a comet's tail	Cut in two in the oldest story, they want Fixed Fate to make their stolen immortality permanent and whole	**The Eclipse (two bodies, one fight):** Rahu swallows one reel tube each round (it goes dark); Ketu strikes with a blind random wheel. If their Omens drift more than 10% apart they rejoin and heal, so keep them **balanced**: Zero-Sum hits both equally.	Returned to the sky as a passing eclipse
Archon Seventeen	Kroton Nova	Gaunt, beautiful, terrifying; a laurel of bronze and a sieve-shaped staff; his Omen is 17	Faith: the Final Audit is purification; only the indivisible deserve to remain	**The Sieve:** each round he strikes digits off *your* wheels (multiples of 2, then 3, then 5..., like the Sieve of Eratosthenes); composite strikes are halved	Falls through his own sieve; Prima saves him
The House, Mr. Eighty-Nine	Crossroads	Elegant old croupier in a white suit, ouroboros tattoo around his throat, a pocket watch running backwards; meets you at the midnight crossroads	Loops the night so his granddaughter never dies at dawn; financed Thale	**The Loop:** every 3 rounds time rewinds, but your reel and charms persist; he copies your last pattern; mid-fight he offers you a **deal**	Lets the dawn come; says goodbye to Fibi
Comptroller Lucan Thale	Meridian	see §4	Fixed Fate	**Three phases:** Regression to the Mean (wheels compress toward 5) → Fixed Fate (wheels stop spinning: a puzzle) → Zero (NIL alone; all companions return as Link Arts)	Depends on ending

Keepers (trials, not villains): Enma in Hyakki (judges whether NIL may pass the shrine) · Judge Cui in the Ten Courts (tests NIL for the Brush) · Chitragupta in Śūnyapura (reads NIL's empty page) · the Moirai in Kroton Nova (Clotho, Lachesis and Atropos each pose one challenge) · the Stranger at the Crossroads (offers the deal). These are elite "trial" fights with special rules and no hatred.

7. Plot beats by act

Prologue: "NaN" (Meridian Undercity) 1. *Intro cinematic* (§8). Dawn Tally; NIL interferes; the Naming Rite; **the player states their lucky number**; REMAINDER DETECTED. 2. Tutorial Audit vs Debt Hounds, alone. 3. Vesper saves NIL ("Need a hand? Seven bucks."). Optional: Maeve's forge in the Celtic quarter, where she joins after you help defend it. 4. Varro corners them at the drain gates. Boss. Spared. 5. **World-map reveal:** Vesper explains the seven Seals; six lands light up on the map in six art styles. Seal 1.

Act I: "The Night Parade" (Hyakki) 1. Arrival by ferry under a Hokusai wave. The Night Parade crosses the bridge, and the party hides inside it. 2. **Hina** jumps out of a shrine's umbrella stand and attaches herself to NIL ("You smell like a hundred wishes"). 3. Shrine of the Seven Lucky Gods (charms); kappa river crossing; **Enma's trial** at the gate of the dead. 4. **Tamamo** in her fox-fire palace. Boss. 5. Tamamo, defeated, asks NIL what a yokai is worth without belief. Seal 9. 6. *Epilogue:* Thale in the Basilica: "The Remainder is learning to count."

Act II: "Eight Bells and the Book of the Dead" (River Empire): the Lantern Festival and the Luck Exchange; Ba Jinling buys the party's bounty and hides them; descent through the river's end into the Ten Courts; **Judge Cui's trial** grants the Brush; **Bai Si** joins; return to face **Jin Chan**; father and daughter. Seal 8.

Act III: "Śūnya" (Śūnyapura): monsoon arrival; Vetāla riddles; **Shunya** at the observatory; **Chitragupta's Hall**, where NIL's page is blank; **the reveal: NIL is the Remainder**; **Rahu & Ketu** eclipse the city. Seal 0.

Act IV: "Indivisible" (Kroton Nova): Prima defects when the Sieve drops a school; **the Moirai's cave** (three trials); **Archon Seventeen**. Seal 2.

Act V: "1,597 Nights" (Crossroads Territory): the midnight crossroads deal; the same night repeating; **Fibi** remembers; Varro returns to help; Vesper's honest hand; **the House** lets dawn come. Seal 7.

Finale: "Zero-Sum" (Meridian): the gate takes six digits and the seventh is **the player's lucky number**. Inside the Basilica, the walls show every land's original ledger. Thale's three phases. The choice.

8. The intro (shot list; full prompts in `art/HIGGSFIELD_PROMPTS.md`)

Total ≈ 2 min 30 s; skippable after first view. The opening montage cycles through **every land's art style** and doubles as the game's best trailer.

#	BEAT	STYLE	LENGTH
1	**"Before numbers, there was the Noise."** Floods, falling towers and hail of dice. Thale narrates.	Abstract ink and static	8 s
2	**"Every people kept its own accounts with fate."** A montage: the Moirai spin a glowing thread (red-figure pottery style) → Chitragupta writes on palm leaves (Indian miniature) → a judge writes in the Book of Life and Death (ink-wash) → Enma opens his ledger as a lantern parade passes (ukiyo-e) → a hand signs a black book at a midnight crossroads (Americana woodcut).	Five art styles, 4 s each	20 s
3	**"Then Meridian built one machine for all of them."** Brass chains pull each ledger into the Basilica; gears swallow them; the Dawn Tally beam sweeps the world and a number appears over every head. "Every soul a number. Every number a share."	Brass clockwork	12 s
4	**Title card:** ZERO-SUM: OMEN	Nixie	4 s
5	**Dawn in the Undercity.** The beam sweeps neon slums; Omens above the crowd tick up and down. A mother's number drops to **01**; her son stares at it.	Anime cyber-noir	15 s
6	**Varro's collectors** arrive to settle her. The crowd parts. One hooded figure doesn't: **NIL**, with **NaN** flickering above.	—	12 s
7	NIL reaches out. **Digits spin** around the mother's 01; NIL *stops* them on 07. The collectors freeze: "That one has no number."	—	10 s
8	Chase through alleys full of every land's charms (horseshoes, chilli-and-lemon strings, beckoning cats, evil-eye beads); NIL ducks into a black-market shrine with a jury-rigged **Naming terminal**. "Every soul needs a number, child."	—	15 s
9	**Interactive: "STATE YOUR LUCKY NUMBER."** The player picks 0–9; each digit shows what it means in the lands of the Tally.	In-engine	player-paced
10	The terminal overloads. Across the city every screen and Omen glitches to **REMAINDER DETECTED**; the Basilica's eye opens; bounty posters print NIL's face.	—	12 s
11	Logo slam with the chosen digit, then straight into gameplay: Debt Hounds leap from the rooftops.	In-engine	4 s

9. Endings

ENDING	CONDITION	WHAT HAPPENS
Balance	Return the Remainder	NIL dissolves into the Ledger. Every Omen rises by one; the Deficit closes. The party visits a grave with no number.
Overflow	Break the Basilica	Every Omen becomes NaN. Nobody can see anyone's luck: freedom and chaos. Each land returns to its old ways, for better and worse.
Positive-Sum (true ending)	All 8 bonds complete; every companion's ledger piece kept	The party puts every land's ledger piece back into the Basilica *together*: thread, karma, the Book and the Brush, Enma's page, the crossroads contract, Maeve's horseshoe. The machine stops forcing one law and starts translating between many. Shared luck stops being conserved and starts **multiplying**. The game's synergy system (heroes worth more together than apart) becomes the world's new law. Thale lives to see it.
Divide by Zero (secret)	NIL's digit is 0 and the final hit lands 0-0-0	The Basilica crashes, the screen blue-screens, and the credits roll in debug text.

The theme in one sentence: *a world that flattened every culture's idea of luck into one zero-sum number learns, from a party drawn from all of them, that luck shared isn't zero-sum.*

10. Cultural care

- Each land is **inspired by** a real culture and is not a depiction of a real country. Names are invented or drawn from widely told public folklore.
- **Revered deities and sacred figures are never enemies.** Enma, Chitragupta, Judge Cui and the Moirai are keepers who test the party with respect. Villains are mortals, legendary monsters from the stories themselves (Tamamo, Rahu and Ketu, the Headless Horseman), or Thale's officials.
- Rahu and Ketu are also venerated as celestial bodies in Hindu astronomy and astrology. Present them as tragic, cosmic and awe-inspiring, never as cheap demons, and have the depiction reviewed.
- **Avoid Indigenous sacred traditions** in the American act (no dreamcatchers, skinwalkers or sacred ceremonies). The Crossroads draws on frontier tall tales, the blues crossroads legend, immigrant superstitions, ghost towns and Sleepy Hollow.
- **Hire or consult reviewers from each culture** (Japanese, Chinese, Indian, Greek, American) for names, scripts (kanji, hanzi, Devanagari, Greek), clothing and terms before any public release. Localise to Japanese, Simplified and Traditional Chinese, and Hindi post-jam.
- The casino is aesthetic only: no real-money mechanics or purchasable randomness.

PART III

Lore lexicon

Every word, date and rule, kept consistent.



Use this file to keep every word, date and rule consistent across writing, art, UI and marketing.

1. Glossary

TERM	MEANING	USAGE NOTES
The Tally	The known world: Meridian plus the ring of lands around it	"Across the Tally"; never "the world map" in dialogue
Omen	A soul's share of luck, 00–99, visible as a number floating over the head	Always two digits: "Omen 07", not "Omen 7". Plural: Omens.
NaN	NIL's non-number glitch	Written exactly "NaN"; characters pronounce it "nan"
The Basilica	The brass clockwork cathedral-engine in Meridian that computes every Omen	"The Basilica" (capitalised). Never "the machine" in formal speech.
The Ledger	The merged record of every Omen held by the Basilica	Distinct from the older, local ledgers (Enma's ledger, the Book of Life and Death, Chitragupta's records, the Moirai's thread, the Black Book)
Dawn Tally	The daily recomputation of every Omen at sunrise; a beam sweeps the city	Clocks in Meridian strike 0 at dawn
The Rounding	The dropping of every soul's fractional luck at each Dawn Tally	Secret until Act II/III
The Remainder	The accumulated rounded-off luck, embodied as NIL	Basilica alerts: "REMAINDER DETECTED"
The Deficit	The leak in the world's total luck that causes Noise storms	Theologians speak of "the books not balancing"
The Default	The predicted collapse of the Basilica and return of the Noise	Used like "doomsday"
Noise / Noise storm	Patches of pure chance where numbers scramble; where Noiselings come from	Visual: static, scrambled digits, glitch colour
Noiseling	Small glitch creature made of scrambled digits	Common enemy
Settled	Reaching Omen 00: misfortune takes you, and your luck returns to the pool	Funerals are "settlings"; "may you never settle" is a blessing
Audit	A duel of fates; combat	"Audit him" = fight him
Auditor	Someone who can summon and stop a Fate Wheel; also the title of the six Seal-holders	Capitalise as a title ("the Auditor of Hyakki")
Fate Wheel	The spinning strip of digits summoned in an Audit (descended from Fortune's wheel, *Rota Fortunae*)	Players say "wheel"
The reel	The three slots where stopped digits land; styled per land	Never "slot machine" in dialogue
Naming Rite	The ceremony at age seven where a child states their lucky number to the Basilica	In the intro, NIL performs it at a black-market terminal
Lucky number / resonant digit	The digit a soul resonates with	Gameplay: the hero's synergy digit
Seal / Seal Digit	The lock binding each land's ledger into the Basilica; the gate needs 7 digits	Seven digits: 1, 9, 8, 0, 2, 7 + the player's number
Final Audit	Thale's plan: settle the Remainder, then Fixed Fate	—
Fixed Fate	Freezing every Omen forever	Thale calls it "mercy"
Keepers	Revered guardians of the old ledgers (Enma, Judge Cui, Chitragupta, the Moirai)	Never "bosses" in text
Luck-in	A single point of Omen sold for food or favours	Slum slang
Fen	Small coins used across the Tally	"Eight fen for a bowl of noodles"
Overwrite	Landing your own lucky digit three times	Gameplay and in-world slang for a miracle

2. Idioms and slang

- "Rounded down": cheated, or killed.
- "In the black": safe, lucky. "In the red": in debt, unlucky.
- "Lucky as a ninety-nine": very lucky (Meridian); in Hyakki it's an insult, since 9 means suffering.
- "Don't count your fen at the table."
- "May your Omen never round": goodbye or blessing.
- "Settle down!" is a grim joke in Meridian.
- Swearing: "Default take you", "Noise and ruin".

3. Timeline (Tally Reckoning, TR)

YEAR	EVENT
Before TR	**The Noise**: fortune moves like weather
Ancient (many centuries)	**The Many Ledgers**: each land develops its own accounting with fate (the Moirai's thread, Chitragupta's records, the Book of Life and Death, Enma's ledger, the Black Book of the Crossroads)
~1,000 years before TR	Zero formalised in Śūnyapura
TR 0	Meridian founded as a trading city at the centre of the Tally
TR 380–690	**The Binding**: Meridian's actuaries copy, buy or seize each land's ledger
TR 702	**The Basilica** completed; first Dawn Tally; the Rounding begins
TR 960	A Noise storm destroys Lucan Thale's street; he is 12
TR 962	The Deficit is first measured by Śūnyapura's observatory
TR 985	Thale becomes Comptroller
TR 999	Thale proves the Rounding; drafts the Final Audit; signs the Seal-holders' pacts
TR 1001	Varro Kade becomes a Collector
TR 1002 (present)	NIL wakes; the Naming Rite; REMAINDER DETECTED. The game begins.

The present year is **TR 1002**, deliberately just past the round 1000.

4. Factions

FACTION	SEAT	WANTS	SYMBOL
The Basilica (Comptroller, clerks, Ledger-priests)	Meridian	Order, the Final Audit	A gear inside a circle with a 0
The Collectors	Meridian	Debts paid; bounties	A hound skull over a ledger seal
The Charm Bazaar guilds	Meridian	Trade, survival, folk luck	A ring of mixed charms
The Yokai Courts	Hyakki	To keep existing	Nine foxfire flames
The Luck Exchange	Bāfā Harbor	Profit	The three-legged toad
The Ten Courts (keepers)	Under the River Empire	The true count of the dead	The Judge's brush
The Observatory	Śūnyapura	Truth by measurement	An astrolabe around a 0
The Pythagorean Synod	Kroton Nova	Purity of number	The sieve
The House	Lucky Strike, Crossroads	The night never ending	The ouroboros

5. World rules (canon locks)

1. Omens are always two digits and always visible to everyone, except NIL's NaN.
2. Only Auditors can stop their own wheel. Most people can't.
3. Luck is conserved under the Basilica. Nothing creates luck except the true ending.
4. Settlement is not instant death; misfortune finds you within days.

5. Keepers cannot be killed and are never framed as evil.
6. The Basilica's light is always Nixie amber; steel numbers belong only to the Basilica's officials.
7. Charms from all cultures work everywhere, weakly; they work best in their home land.
8. No guns of modern military style: weapons are revolvers, blades, staves, hammers, fans, shields and instruments.
9. Technology is retro-futurist brass and Nixie, with no screens except Basilica terminals and Exchange boards.

6. Naming conventions

LAND	RULES	EXAMPLES
Meridian	Mixed origins; surnames that are words or numbers	Vesper Sette, Varro Kade, Maeve Triskel
Hyakki	Japanese-style given names; spirits named by number or object	Hina, Tamamo
River Empire	Chinese-style names with meaningful characters, especially numbers	Ba Jinling (eight golden bells), Bai Si (white four)
Śūnyapura	Sanskrit-derived words for concepts and numbers	Shunya (zero), Purna (fullness)
Kroton Nova	Greek-style, Latin numerals for rank	Prima, Archon Seventeen
Crossroads	Americana nicknames, Italian-American and Irish-American surnames	Fibi Leone, "Mr. Eighty-Nine"

Run every non-English name past a native speaker before release.

PART IV

The lands

Seven places, seven palettes. Travelling between them should feel like changing countries.

PROLOGUE · COSMOPOLITAN CAPITAL · CYBER-NOIR PAINTED CITY

Meridian Undercity

COLOUR SCRIPT

Wet slate	Window amber	Moss	Nixie	Neon yellow	Neon magenta	Neon cyan
#2E3A4B	#E8A04B	#5E7D4A	#FF7A2C	#F5E400	#FF2E88	#00E5FF





Pass 1 exploration art, in the superseded style. Kept for reference; to be redone under Art Direction v2. The Hyakki pier deck plate is the usable layout for the battle stage.

ACT I · JAPANESE FOLKLORE · UKIYO-E + PAINTED NIGHT

Hyakki

COLOUR SCRIPT

Indigo	Ink blue	Paper	Vermilion	Lantern gold	Firefly
#1B2440	#2E4A7A	#F2E6C9	#E34234	#F2B33D	#9BD15A







Pass 1 exploration art, in the superseded style. Kept for reference; to be redone under Art Direction v2. The Hyakki pier deck plate is the usable layout for the battle stage.

ACT II · CHINESE FOLK RELIGION · GONGBI GOLD + INK-WASH UNDERWORLD

The River Empire

COLOUR SCRIPT

Jade	Ochre	Red lacquer	Gold leaf	Rice paper	Ink green
#00A86B	#C8963E	#B22222	#D4AF37	#E9E2D0	#3A4A3F

Environment art pending

Establishing shot and battle stage to be generated with the background suffix in Art Direction §6, using this land's palette and the Locations Guide.

ACT III · INDIAN MYTH & MATHEMATICS · MINIATURE PAINTING + MONSOON LIGHT

Śūnyapura

COLOUR SCRIPT

Sandstone	Peacock	Saffron	Indigo	Brass	Eclipse
#D8A86B	#1E7B6F	#F4A300	#3F3D99	#B5893B	#4B2A6B

Environment art pending

Establishing shot and battle stage to be generated with the background suffix in Art Direction §6, using this land's palette and the Locations Guide.

ACT IV · GREEK MYTH · MARBLE, MOSAIC, AEGEAN NOON

Kroton Nova

COLOUR SCRIPT

Chalk	Aegean	Olive	Bronze	Sky
#F4F1EA	#1F6FB2	#7A8B4A	#8C6A3F	#D6E6F2

Environment art pending

Establishing shot and battle stage to be generated with the background suffix in Art Direction §6, using this land's palette and the Locations Guide.

ACT V · AMERICAN FOLKLORE · DESERT SUNSET + CASINO NEON

The Crossroads Territory

COLOUR SCRIPT

Rust	Sage	Dusk violet	Sunset	Midnight	Neon pink
#B7410E	#9CAF88	#5B3E73	#F28C28	#1D1A3A	#FF2E88

Environment art pending

Establishing shot and battle stage to be generated with the background suffix in Art Direction §6, using this land's palette and the Locations Guide.

The Basilica

COLOUR SCRIPT

Brass	Steel	Steel white	Nixie	Ink
#B5A642	#8E9196	#E8E6E1	#FF7A2C	#141018

Environment art pending

Establishing shot and battle stage to be generated with the background suffix in Art Direction §6, using this land's palette and the Locations Guide.

One page per land: what it is, how it looks, sounds and feels, and where the fights happen. Colour scripts and rendering rules are in `ART_DIRECTION.md` §4 and §8.

Meridian Undercity (Prologue) and the Basilica (Finale)

- **Inspired by:** a cosmopolitan modern capital; the immigrant quarters of every great port city.
- **Geography:** a plateau city; the Undercity is stacked in the drains and cliffs beneath it, with the Basilica's tower rising from the plateau's heart.
- **Districts:** the Remainder Wards (Remainder + Charmpunk) · the Charm Bazaar (pure Charmpunk) · the Exchange Terraces (Gilded Fortune over Ledgerism) · the Basilica Ring (pure Ledgerism).
- **Key locations:** Rain Alley 9 (where NIL wakes) · the black-market Naming shrine · Maeve's forge in the Celtic quarter · the drain gates (Varro's boss fight) · the sealed Upper Gate · the Basilica nave (finale).
- **Little things:** charms of every culture over every door; laundry between tenements; balcony gardens (a garden is luck you can see); cats; hand-painted lucky numbers.
- **Sound:** rain, Nixie hum, distant Dawn Tally bells, street musicians, Collector sirens.
- **Battle stages:** Rain Alley · the drain gates · the Bazaar crossroads · the Basilica nave.
- **Reel object:** a dead three-tube Nixie sign.

Hyakki (百鬼), the Isles of a Hundred Demons (Act I)

- **Inspired by:** Japanese folklore (yokai, tsukumogami, the Seven Lucky Gods, Enma); ukiyo-e and Edo-period towns.
- **Geography:** a chain of volcanic islands, cedar forests, terraced fishing towns, torii gates on every hill.
- **Culture:** humans and yokai share festivals; numbers 4 (*shi*) and 9 (*ku*) are avoided; 7 and 8 are blessed.
- **Key locations:** Moon Pier (arrival; battle stage) · the Night Parade bridge · the Shrine of the Seven Lucky Gods · the kappa river · Enma's gate of the dead (keeper trial) · Tamamo's foxfire palace (boss).
- **Little things:** daruma dolls with one eye painted; beckoning cats; fireflies; wind chimes; one tired kappa selling cucumbers.
- **Sound:** shamisen, shakuhachi, taiko for battle, cicadas and wind chimes.
- **Meridian intrusion:** a Ledgerist toll gate on the shrine road; Collectors in the harbour.
- **Reel object:** a torii with three hanging lanterns.

The River Empire: Bāfā Harbor (八发港) and the Ten Courts (十殿) (Act II)

- **Inspired by:** Chinese folk religion, festival culture and river trade.
- **Geography:** a great golden river delta; the harbor city of Bāfā on its banks; the river's end falls into the underworld of the Ten Courts.
- **Key locations:** the Lantern Festival · the Luck Exchange (live Omen price boards) · Jinling's pawnshop · the river's end · Naihe Bridge and Meng Po's pavilion · the Hall of the Book (Judge Cui's trial) · Jin Chan's coin palace (boss).
- **Little things:** red envelopes, mahjong tables, dragon boats, joss paper drifting into the river, lucky 8s on every price tag.
- **Sound:** erhu, guzheng, firecrackers, abacus clicks; the underworld is silent except for brush strokes.
- **Meridian intrusion:** the Exchange is half Basilica office, half temple.
- **Reel object:** a golden abacus (harbor); a floating ghost ledger (underworld).

Śūnyapura, the City Where Zero Was Born (Act III)

- **Inspired by:** Indian mythology, astronomy and mathematics; stepwells; open-air stone observatories.
- **Geography:** a monsoon plain; a city built around a colossal stone observatory; deep geometric stepwells.
- **Key locations:** the Great Observatory · the Stepwell of a Thousand Steps · the Hall of Chitragupta (keeper trial) · the Vetāla banyan · the eclipse plateau (Rahu & Ketu).
- **Little things:** a lemon and seven chillies over every door; rangoli patterns; chai stalls; pigeons; monsoon puddles mirroring the instruments.
- **Sound:** sitar, tabla, temple bells, rain on stone.

- **Meridian intrusion:** Basilica surveyors re-measuring the observatory's numbers.
- **Reel object:** three sundial dials.

Kroton Nova, the Sieve of the Aegean (Act IV)

- **Inspired by:** Greek mythology and Pythagorean number mysticism.
- **Geography:** a white island city built as a vast stone sieve over a blue sea; the cave of the Moirai beneath.
- **Key locations:** the Agora of Primes · the Sieve terraces · the undercity of the fallen (Remainder shanties) · the Moirai's cave (three trials) · the Archon's temple (boss).
- **Little things:** blue evil-eye beads; olive trees; goats on the terraces; mosaics of numbers.
- **Sound:** lyre, bouzouki, waves, chanting of primes.
- **Meridian intrusion:** the undercity of the "composite" people built from Basilica scrap.
- **Reel object:** three marble columns with mosaic numerals.

The Crossroads Territory (Act V)

- **Inspired by:** American folklore: frontier tall tales, the blues crossroads legend, immigrant charms, desert highways and casinos.
- **Geography:** a desert plateau crossed by highways; the casino boomtown of Lucky Strike, where the same night repeats.
- **Key locations:** the midnight crossroads (the deal) · Route 7 motels · the Ghost Train · the Hollow (the Headless Horseman) · the House's casino (boss).
- **Little things:** horseshoes over doors (open end up); rabbit's-foot keychains; lucky pennies on the railway; diners; neon cacti.
- **Sound:** slide guitar, harmonica, a slot-machine choir, coyotes.
- **Meridian intrusion:** the casino is financed by the Basilica; Collectors deal blackjack.
- **Reel object:** a giant slot machine.

The Far Lands (expansions)

Norse North (the Norns) · Kemet (Ma'at's scales) · the Long Count (Maya zero) · Anansi's Coast (Akan folklore) · the House of Wisdom (al-Khwārizmī). Each needs cultural consultants before design begins.

PART V

Characters

Model pages first, then the full character bible.



NIL

Player's choice



Pass 1 exploration art, in the superseded style. Kept for reference; to be redone under Art Direction v2.

FROM **Meridian Undercity**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Nixie orange
#FF7A2C

Ink black
#141018

Bone white
#EDE6DA

Rim cyan
#00E5FF

CANON LOCKS

- Decoder on the RIGHT wrist
- One orange streak in white hair
- Halo reads exactly "NaN"
- Coat's left tail is longer
- Amber eyes

Vesper Sette

7



Pass 1 exploration art, in the superseded style. Kept for reference; to be redone under Art Direction v2.

FROM **Meridian / Crossroads**

SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Crimson
#E5243B

Black
#141018

Brass
#B5A642

Shirt white
#F4F1EA

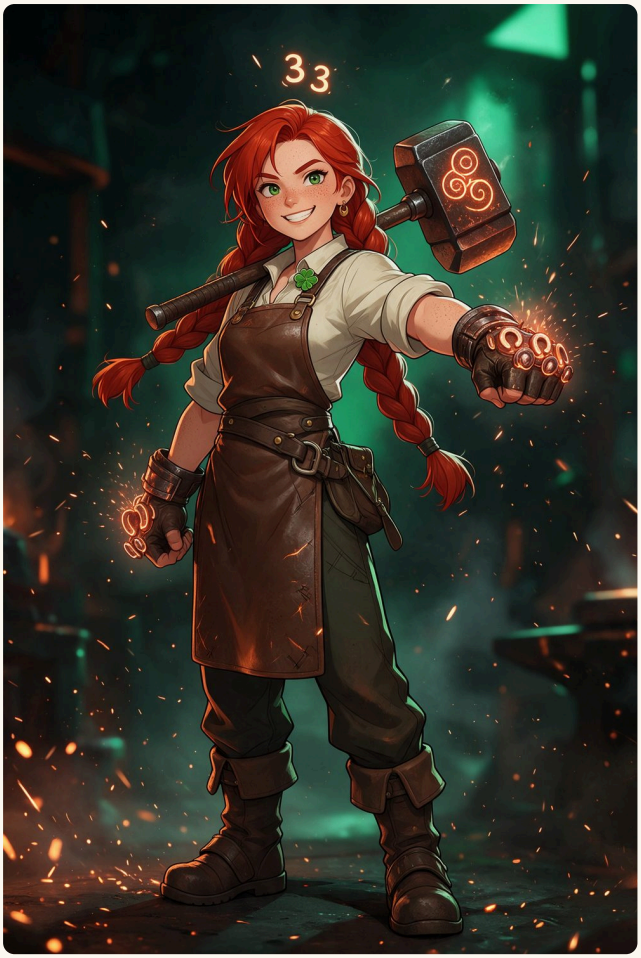
CANON LOCKS

- Exactly 7 chambers
- Scar on the lip
- Braid over the LEFT shoulder
- Crimson + black + brass only

CHARM-SMITH · COMPANION

Maeve Triskel

3



Pass 1 exploration art, in the superseded style. Kept for reference; to be redone under Art Direction v2.

FROM **Meridian, Celtic quarter**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Copper	Clover	Leather
#D9822B	#3BB273	#6B4226

Red hair
#C0392B

CANON LOCKS

- Exactly 3 braids
- Triskele on the hammer
- Clover pin on the collar

Hina of the Ninety-Nine

9



Pass 1 exploration art, in the superseded style. Kept for reference; to be redone under Art Direction v2.

FROM **Hyakki**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Vermilion
#E34234

Indigo
#26428B

Paper
#F2E6C9

Gold
#F2B33D

CANON LOCKS

- The umbrella has ONE eye and a tongue
- Kimono numbers stop at 99
- Never reaches 100 before the finale

Ba Jinling

8

Key art pending

Generate with the character suffix in Art Direction §6 and the description in the Character Bible.

FROM **River Empire**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Jade
#00A86B

Gold
#F4C430

Lacquer red
#B22222

Violet eyes
#5D3A7A

CANON LOCKS

- Exactly 8 bells
- Abacus-rib fan
- Jade + gold palette

Bai Si

4

Key art pending

Generate with the character suffix in Art Direction §6 and the description in the Character Bible.

FROM **River Empire (Ten Courts)**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Mourning white
#F4F1EA

Ink
#1B1B1B

Talisman yellow
#E8C547

Lantern
#F2B33D

CANON LOCKS

- Always 4 lanterns, 4 talismans
- White robes only
- Never smiles before Act IV

Shunya

0

Key art pending

Generate with the character suffix in Art Direction §6 and the description in the Character Bible.

FROM **Śūnyapura**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Indigo
#3F3D99

Saffron
#F4A300

Brass
#B5893B

Mirror silver
#C9CED6

CANON LOCKS

- The brass astrolabe
- Mirror-work embroidery
- "Zero isn't nothing."

Prima of Kroton

2

Key art pending

Generate with the character suffix in Art Direction §6 and the description in the Character Bible.

FROM **Kroton Nova**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Aegean blue	White gold	Chalk
#1F6FB2	#E9DDB3	#F4F1EA

Glass blue
#6FB7E9

CANON LOCKS

- Sieve shield
- 2-3-5-7 halo
- Short hair

DEALER · COMPANION

Fibi Leone

Fibonacci

Key art pending

Generate with the character suffix in Art Direction §6 and the description in the Character Bible.

FROM **Crossroads**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Gold
#F2B33D

Midnight
#1D1A3A

Card white
#F4F1EA

Neon pink
#FF2E88

CANON LOCKS

- 1,597 nights
- Spiral irises
- Her digit changes every round

PROLOGUE BOSS → ALLY

Varro Kade

61



Pass 1 exploration art, in the superseded style. Kept for reference; to be redone under Art Direction v2.

FROM **Meridian**

SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Rust
#B7410E

Gunmetal
#4A4E54

Debt-jar glow
#FF7A2C

Mask bone
#E3DCCB

CANON LOCKS

- Hound-skull mask
- Glass debt jars
- "61" in red

ACT I BOSS

Tamamo

Nine tails



Pass 1 exploration art, in the superseded style. Kept for reference; to be redone under Art Direction v2.

FROM **Hyakki**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Violet	Gold	Foxfire cyan
#8E44AD	#F4C430	#7FDBFF

White
#F4F1EA

CANON LOCKS

- Nine tails, each tipped with a digit
- Foxfire is cold cyan-violet
- Modest court robes (paint-over)

ACT II BOSS

Chancellor Jin Chan

88

Key art pending

Generate with the character suffix in Art Direction §6 and the description in the Character Bible.

FROM **River Empire**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Gold	Toad green	Red
#D4AF37	#6B8E23	#B22222

CANON LOCKS

- Three-legged toad throne
- Coins spill from his mouth

ACT III BOSS

Rahu & Ketu

Eclipse

Key art pending

Generate with the character suffix in Art Direction §6 and the description in the Character Bible.

FROM **Śūnyapura**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Eclipse purple	Corona gold	Night
#4B2A6B	#F4A300	#141018

CANON LOCKS

- Awe-inspiring, never grotesque
- Two bodies, one fight
- Cultural review required

ACT IV BOSS

Archon Seventeen

17

Key art pending

Generate with the character suffix in Art Direction §6 and the description in the Character Bible.

FROM **Kroton Nova**

I

SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Bronze	Chalk	Sieve white
#8C6A3F	#F4F1EA	#DDE6EE

CANON LOCKS

- Bronze laurel
- Sieve staff
- Cold "17"

ACT V BOSS

The House

89

Key art pending

Generate with the character suffix in Art Direction §6 and the description in the Character Bible.

FROM **Crossroads**



SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Ivory	Casino red	Gold
#F4F1EA	#C0392B	#D4AF37

CANON LOCKS

- White suit
- Ouroboros tattoo
- Backwards pocket watch

FINAL ANTAGONIST

Comptroller Lucan Thale 50 (steel)



Pass 1 exploration art, in the superseded style. Kept for reference; to be redone under Art Direction v2.

FROM **Meridian**

SILHOUETTE SHAPE

PALETTE

Steel white	Brass	Nixie
#E8E6E1	#B5A642	#FF7A2C

Steel
#8E9196

CANON LOCKS

- Gear monocle
- Steel, never glowing, "50"
- Never shouts

The single reference for how every character looks, talks, moves and changes. Story context lives in `WORLD_BIBLE.md`; visual rules in `ART_DIRECTION.md`. **Canon locks** are details that must never change between artists, writers or animators.

0. Cast at a glance

CHARACTER	ROLE	DIGIT	FROM	SHAPE	SIGNATURE COLOUR	RECRUITED / MET
NIL	Protagonist, the Remainder	player's choice	Meridian Undercity	Tall rectangle + broken circle	Nixie orange `#FF7A2C`	—
Vesper Sette	Companion, gunslinger	7	Meridian / Crossroads	Triangles	Crimson `#E5243B`	Prologue
Maeve Triskel	Companion, charm-smith	3	Meridian's Celtic quarter	Circles, arcs	Copper `#D9822B` + clover `#3BB273`	Prologue (optional)
Hina of the Ninety-Nine	Companion, tsukumogami	9	Hyakki	Dome on a small body	Vermilion `#E34234` + indigo `#26428B`	Act I
Ba Jinling	Companion, financier	8	River Empire	Fan, hexagon	Jade `#00A86B` + gold `#F4C430`	Act II
Bai Si	Companion, executioner	4	River Empire (Ten Courts)	Tall vertical, square shoulders	Mourning white `#F4F1EA` + ink `#1B1B1B`	Act II
Shunya	Companion, astronomer	0	Śūnyapura	Circle (the astrolabe)	Indigo `#3F3D99` + saffron `#F4A300`	Act III
Prima of Kroton	Companion, paladin	2	Kroton Nova	Shield circle on a sturdy frame	Aegean blue `#1F6FB2` + white-gold	Act IV
Fibi Leone	Companion, dealer	Fibonacci	Crossroads	Spiral	Gold `#F2B33D` + midnight `#1D1A3A`	Act V
Varro Kade	Boss (Prologue), later ally	61	Meridian	Square block	Rust `#B7410E`	Prologue
Tamamo	Boss (Act I)	99 (tails)	Hyakki	Fan and crescents	Violet `#8E44AD` + gold	Act I
Chancellor Jin Chan	Boss (Act II)	88	River Empire	Sphere	Gold `#D4AF37`	Act II
Rahu & Ketu	Boss (Act III)	eclipse	Śūnyapura	Circle + serpent line	Eclipse purple `#4B2A6B`	Act III
Archon Seventeen	Boss (Act IV)	17	Kroton Nova	Tall narrow column	Bronze `#8C6A3F` + chalk	Act IV
The House (Octavian Nine)	Boss (Act V)	89	Crossroads	Circle within a circle (ouroboros)	Ivory white + casino red	Act V
Comptroller Lucan Thale	Final antagonist	50 (steel)	Meridian	Cathedral arch	Steel white `#E8E6E1` + brass `#B5A642`	Intro (voice), Finale

Readability rule: every character must be identifiable as a solid black silhouette at 64 px tall, and by colour alone (Imaishi's principle: in 2D animation, characters are told apart mainly by colour).

1. NIL, the Remainder

Age / build	~19 (appears); 1.74 m; lean, long-legged, slightly hunched when thinking
Pronouns	They/them in all writing. NIL never defines their own gender, and nobody in the world asks.
Wardrobe	Long asymmetric black actuary's coat (left tail longer), high collar, three brass ledger clasps down the right side, fingerless black gloves, slim black trousers, tall boots
Props	Cracked brass **decoder** fused into the **right** wrist; leaks orange light and tiny floating digits when emotional
Omen	A broken holographic **NaN** glitch where an Omen should be; it flickers faster under stress

Personality	Quiet, observant, dry. Counts things under their breath when anxious (stairs, raindrops, people). Fascinated by other people's numbers. Kind without announcing it.
Flaw	Disappears into calculation instead of feeling; assumes they're a problem to be solved
Want → need	Wants a number and a normal life. Needs to accept being what everyone lost, and choose what to give back.
Voice	Short sentences. Precise words. Questions more than statements. Deadpan humour. Never swears.
Sample lines	"Fourteen steps. You've rounded down two of them." · "Everyone here has a number. I just have a question." · "If I'm what the world lost… I'd like to be returned carefully."
Animation personality	Economical movement; snaps into action. Idle: turns the decoder wrist, digits drift up. Victory: closes a fist on a locked digit, small exhale. On their lucky digit: halo stabilises for one frame. On a Bust: tilts their head, recalculating.
Growth	One new verb per act (GDD §6) and one memory flashback per Seal, each drawn in that land's art style
Canon locks	Decoder on the RIGHT wrist · one orange streak in white hair · halo reads "NaN" exactly · the coat's left tail is longer · amber eyes

2. Vesper Sette (7)

Age / build	28; 1.82 m; long limbs, sharp angles
Wardrobe	Wide-brim black hat with two playing cards in the band; crimson duster with triangular tails; black croupier waistcoat; white shirt, sleeves rolled; cards in her garters
Props	Revolver with a **seven-chamber** cylinder engraved 1–7; a worn silver coin she flips before every decision and ignores
Personality	Gambler's bravado, dry jokes, generous with strangers, merciless with cheats. Guilt she won't name.
Flaw	Treats every relationship as a bet she can walk away from
Want → need	Wants to stay one step ahead of her past. Needs to deal one honest hand.
Secret	Dealt the rigged hand at the House that Settled a twelve-year-old boy
Voice	Drawl, card and dice slang, calls NIL "Kid" until Act III, then by name
Sample lines	"Need a hand? Seven bucks." · "Luck's just math somebody else is hiding from you." · "I always flip. I never look."
Animation	Fan-the-hammer shooting; reloads by spinning the cylinder like a roulette wheel; idle hat tip; grins and spins the cylinder when a 7 lands
Bond arc	(1) Teaches NIL to read tells · (2) admits the rigged hand · (3) faces the House · (4) deals an honest hand to Fibi
Canon locks	Exactly 7 chambers · scar on the lip · crimson + black + brass only · braid over the LEFT shoulder

3. Maeve Triskel (3)

Age / build	20; 1.65 m; strong arms, freckled
Wardrobe	Leather forge apron, rolled work shirt, heavy boots; red hair in **three** braids
Props	Horseshoe-knuckle gauntlets (glow copper-hot when charged); forge hammer with a triskele burned into the head; four-leaf-clover pin
Personality	Loud, warm, superstitious about everything and proud of it; adopts every stray
Flaw	Stubborn; believes charms can fix things that need words
Want → need	Wants to make her grandmother's charms work again. Needs to accept that luck is something people make together.
Backstory	Her family's homeland luck was "rounded" into the Basilica; the day it happened, her grandmother's charms stopped working. She makes new ones.
Voice	Fast, warm, a little Irish-inflected; touches wood; says "third time's the charm" at every opportunity
Sample lines	"Horseshoe goes open end UP, or the luck falls out. Honestly." · "Three braids, three tries, three hits. That's just maths."
Animation	Swings with her whole body; kisses her clover pin when a 3 lands; hammer-on-anvil sparks as a victory pose
Canon locks	Exactly 3 braids · triskele on the hammer · clover pin on the collar

4. Hina of the Ninety-Nine (九十九 雛, 9)

Age / build	99 years old (as an umbrella); appears ~12; 1.35 m
Wardrobe	Furisode kimono in indigo and vermilion patterned with numbers 1–99; big obi bow; geta sandals; black bob
Props	Red-and-white oiled-paper umbrella with **one eye and a long tongue** (it's her true body; it has its own expressions)
Personality	Mischievous, ancient and childish at once; obsessed with turning 100; secretly scared of not being "real"
Want → need	Wants to reach 100 and become a "proper" spirit. Needs to decide she's already real.
Backstory	A 99-year-old umbrella left at Enma's shrine, soaked in a century of wishes, woke up one year early. Fixed Fate would freeze her at 99 forever.
Voice	Formal old-fashioned phrasing mixed with kid slang; refers to herself in the third person when excited ("Hina approves!")
Sample lines	"One more year and Hina would've been a *real* spirit. Don't you dare freeze me now." · "You smell like a hundred wishes."
Animation	Rides the umbrella; the umbrella reacts separately (blinks, sticks its tongue out on a 9); twirls on a Jackpot
Cultural note	Based on *tsukumogami* and *kasa-obake* folklore; keep her playful, never creepy-cute fan service
Canon locks	The umbrella has ONE eye · kimono numbers stop at 99 · she never reaches 100 before the finale

5. Ba Jinling (八金铃, 8)

Age / build	31; 1.70 m; poised
Wardrobe	Modern jade-and-gold qipao with a high slit and structured shoulders; eight tiny golden bells in hair ornaments and anklets
Props	Folding fan whose ribs are **abacus rods** (beads fly as projectiles)
Personality	Theatrical, sly, mercenary on the surface; buys poor people's debts and burns them in secret
Want → need	Wants to outplay her father. Needs to stop hiding her kindness behind business.
Backstory	Chancellor Jin Chan's daughter; left the Luck Exchange when she learned what built his fortune
Voice	Silk and knives; speaks in interest rates ("That favour will cost you eight percent, compounding.")
Sample lines	"Everyone's in debt, darling. I just keep better books." · "Eight bells. Count them. You won't hear the ninth."
Animation	Fan snap; every gesture rings a bell; collects coins mid-fight with a flick
Canon locks	Exactly 8 bells · the abacus fan · jade + gold palette

6. Bai Si (白四, 4)

Age / build	Looks ~35; 1.95 m; long and still
Wardrobe	White mourning robes (white is the mourning colour in Chinese tradition) inked with 四; black funeral ribbon in long white hair
Props	Huge guandao-style blade hung with four paper talismans; joss paper drifts around him; four floating lanterns
Personality	Stoic, formal, honour-bound; unexpectedly tender with children and the old; dry humour arrives late in the story
Want → need	Wants the count of the dead to be correct. Needs to forgive himself for centuries of wrong counts.
Backstory	The Ten Courts' executioner who counts every Settled soul. NIL shows him the Rounding; his count was always short.
Voice	Few words, archaic and formal; never uses contractions
Sample lines	"Everyone dies. I only keep count." · "Four lanterns. I have never needed a fifth."
Animation	Almost motionless idle; each strike extinguishes one lantern; closes his eyes when a 4 lands
Canon locks	Always 4 lanterns and 4 talismans · white robes, never coloured · never smiles before Act IV

7. Shunya (शून्य, 0)

Age / build	23; 1.62 m; restless energy
Wardrobe	Indigo-and-saffron layered clothing with mirror-work embroidery; long dark braid with brass astrolabe hairpins; ink-stained fingers

Props	Brass astrolabe (spun as a weapon), palm-leaf manuscripts tied at her hip
Personality	Brilliant, impatient, joyful about ideas, gentle with people who are slow
Want → need	Wants to prove her Deficit calculations. Needs to remember the answer is a person (NIL), not a number.
Backstory	Works at the great observatory where her ancestors formalised zero; found that the Deficit equals exactly one person's worth of luck
Voice	Talks fast, interrupts herself, explains with her hands; calls zero "the place that holds everything"
Sample lines	"Zero isn't nothing. It's room." · "The books are short by one soul. Exactly one. Hello."
Animation	Spins the astrolabe like a discus; sketches equations in the air in light; beams when a 0 lands
Cultural note	Draws on Indian mathematical history (zero, place value); have the design and clothing reviewed
Canon locks	The astrolabe · mirror-work embroidery · the line "Zero isn't nothing."

8. Prima of Kroton (2)

Age / build	18; 1.68 m; sturdy
Wardrobe	White-and-gold armour with Greek-key borders; short blonde hair; blue eyes
Props	Giant round shield shaped like a sieve set with blue glass; a halo of floating glyphs 2-3-5-7
Personality	Earnest, loud, honest to a fault; comic relief who becomes the moral backbone
Want → need	Wants to be a proper member of the Synod. Needs to see that "indivisible" means people, not numbers.
Backstory	2 is "the even prime", the odd one out among primes, and so is she
Voice	Formal battle cries, then clumsy apologies; counts primes to calm down
Sample lines	"Two! Three! Five! Seven! …I'm calm." · "If the Sieve drops children, the Sieve is wrong."
Animation	Shield-bash; plants her feet like a statue; trips once per fight in idle
Canon locks	The sieve shield · the 2-3-5-7 halo · short hair

9. Fibi Leone (Fibonacci)

Age / build	18; 1.60 m; jittery
Wardrobe	Tailored croupier tailcoat and headset; golden spiral curls; spiral-patterned irises
Props	A deck of glowing cards that flows around her in a golden spiral
Personality	Fast-talking, anxious, brilliant; laughs at bad moments; has lived the same night 1,597 times
Want → need	Wants the night to end. Needs to accept the dawn, even though it may kill her.
Twist	Her grandfather, the House, loops the night so she never dies at dawn
Voice	Rapid; counts in Fibonacci; finishes other people's sentences (she's heard them before)
Sample lines	"You're going to say 'Who are you?' Then you'll trip on the third step. …See?" · "One, one, two, three, five. That's how I breathe."
Animation	Deals cards in spirals; her lucky digit glows in a different place every round
Canon locks	1,597 nights · spiral irises · her digit changes every round

10. Antagonists and keepers

CHARACTER	LOOK (LOCKS)	MOTIVE	VOICE	FATE
Varro Kade	Hound-skull mask, rust trench armour, glass debt jars on his belt, "61" in red	Buy his sister's exemption	Growls in debt-collector jargon: "Interest is due."	Spared; helps in Act V
Tamamo	Nine glowing tails each tipped with a digit, Heian court robes in violet and gold, foxfire	Keep the yokai from fading	Teasing, archaic, kind cruelty	Retreats into legend; blesses Hina

CHARACTER	LOOK (LOCKS)	MOTIVE	VOICE	FATE
Jin Chan	Gold-coin robes, three-legged toad throne, coins spill from his mouth	Hold the world's frozen luck in his bank	Booming, jolly, transactional	Bankrupted; Jinling takes over
Rahu & Ketu	A vast crowned celestial head and a headless serpent body with a comet tail; awe-inspiring, never grotesque	Make their stolen immortality permanent	Rahu speaks; Ketu answers only in tremors	Returned to the sky as a passing eclipse
Archon Seventeen	Gaunt, bronze laurel, sieve staff, cold "17"	Purify the world: only the indivisible should remain	Soft, scholarly, absolute	Falls through his own sieve; Prima saves him
The House	White suit, ouroboros tattoo on his throat, backwards pocket watch	Keep his granddaughter alive by looping the night	Old-world charm, gentle menace	Lets the dawn come
Comptroller Thale	White-and-brass cathedral vestments, gear monocle, steel "50"	Fixed Fate: end all loss by ending all chance	Calm, kind, exhausted; never shouts	Depends on the ending
Keepers (Enma, Judge Cui, Chitragupta, the Moirai)	Shown with reverence: solemn, beautiful, never monstrous	Test the party	Measured, ritual language	They are never "defeated", only satisfied

11. Relationship map

	NIL	VESPER	MAEVE	HINA	JINLING	BAI SI	SHUNYA	PRIMA	FIBI
NIL	—	Big sister / first protector	Best friend	Little sister they adopt	Wary respect → trust	Student of grief	Equal; the one who explains them	Protects her	Mirror (both outside time)
Vesper	Protector	—	Sparring jokes	Teaches her poker	Old rival from the casinos	Respect	Finds her exhausting	Mocks, then defends	Guilt; the honest hand
Maeve	Best friend	Hero-worship	—	Makes her charms	Haggles	Forges his new lanterns	Asks too many questions	Fellow loud one	Big-sister energy
Hina	"Hundred-wish human"	"Hat lady"	Charm-maker	—	Wants her bells	Scared of him, then adores him	Calls her "the zero girl"	Rides on her shield	Twins in being "not quite real"

Party banter rule: every pair of companions has at least one exchange per act; Complement pairs (digits summing to 10) get an extra bond scene.

12. Writing and voice quick rules

1. NIL never wastes a word. Companions talk more than NIL does.
2. Each character has one **number habit**: Vesper flips a coin, Maeve counts threes, Hina counts to 100, Jinling quotes interest, Bai Si counts lanterns, Shunya says "zero isn't nothing", Prima recites primes, Fibi counts in Fibonacci.
3. Villains are never cartoonishly evil; every Auditor's motive is understandable in one sentence.
4. Cultural characters speak as people, not as tour guides; no fake accents in text.
5. No one comments on NIL's gender.

PART VI

Art direction

Painted world, inked people.



"Painted world, inked people." Hand-painted, sunlit, lived-in **worlds in the spirit of Studio Ghibli's backgrounds**, inhabited by **graphic, high-contrast, neon-edged characters and action in the spirit of Studio Trigger's** *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners*.

The two styles are not mixed at random. They carry the game's theme: - **The lands** (the old, plural ways of seeing luck: nature, craft, community) are **painted**: soft air, warm light, weather, moss, laundry, cats on roofs. - **Meridian and the Basilica** (the machine that flattens luck into one number) are **neon and graphic**, and so is **combat**, where numbers fight. - As the story moves, the neon of the machine intrudes on the painted lands (Noise storms, Auditors), and the finale reverses it.

This file replaces the style sections of the prompt pack. If a rule here conflicts with older docs, this file wins.

1. What went wrong in pass 1 (honest diagnosis)

PROBLEM	WHY IT LOOKS CHEAP	FIX IN V2
AI gloss: airbrushed gradients on skin and cloth, plastic highlights, everything rendered to the same detail	Reads as "generic AI anime illustration", not a production frame	Characters use **flat cel shading: 2 tones + 1 hard rim light**, no gradients except a hint on hair. Detail goes where the eye should go.
No hierarchy between character and background: both painted the same way	Characters don't pop; the image is mush	Anime's oldest rule: **flat cel characters on painted backgrounds**. Different rendering for each layer.
Stiff, centred gacha poses from one mannequin	Every character feels like a figurine on a turntable	Poses from **gesture and story**: lunges, leans, foreshortening, Dutch angles for action; quiet, grounded poses for drama.
Muddy teal-and-orange everywhere	No identity; characters don't read at thumbnail size	**One signature colour per character** plus a land colour script (§4). Value contrast first, hue second.
Thin, uniform or missing lineart	Shapes melt into the background	**Variable-weight coloured lines**: thick silhouette, thin interior, line colour tinted toward the local colour (never pure black on skin).
Floating digits and "Nixie" glow everywhere	The motif becomes noise and creates text artefacts	Numbers appear **only where the fiction puts them**: Omens over heads, wheels, the reel, signage.
Over-detailed, evenly lit backgrounds	No air, no time of day, no story	**Atmospheric perspective, one clear light source, weather, and lived-in details** chosen on purpose.

2. The two halves

2.1 The painted world (Ghibli-inspired backgrounds)

What the research says about how those backgrounds are made (sources at the end): - **Medium:** gouache-like *poster colour*, opaque but handled so gradations "look like transparent watercolor"; **a small palette (~21 colours) mixed subtly**; never a thick coat. - **Process:** the base wash goes down wet, on pre-wetted paper, which is where the soft cloud edges and natural gradations come from; detail is added after it dries. - **Philosophy:** *"He's not rendering everything. But he is rendering the little things."* The background painter extracts "the essence of important elements of the scene" and augments it. Backgrounds serve the film's vision, and they come from **on-site observation** (mist rising from valleys, the way real foliage grows), not from photos.

Our rules: 1. **Gouache look**: visible but soft brush texture, opaque colour, wet-edge gradients in skies, slightly matte. No photo textures, no 3D-render sheen. 2. **A limited palette per land** (≈20 colours), mixed subtly. 3. **Light tells the time.** Every background has one motivated light source and a time of day: warm late-afternoon sun, blue dusk, lantern night, rain dawn. 4. **Air.** Distant planes get lighter, cooler and softer (atmospheric perspective). Big skies with towering cumulus or layered stratus. 5. **Render the little things on purpose**: one cat, a drying futon, a bicycle, potted plants on a fire escape, a hand-written shop sign, moss on a stone. Two or three per frame, not fifty. 6. **Nature wins**: plants grow out of everything, even in Meridian. It's the visual sign of the old plural world surviving. 7. **Layouts for play**: battle plates have a clear floor plane, a calm area behind the fighters, and the reel object top-centre (GDD §8).

2.2 The inked people and the fights (Edgerunners-inspired)

What the research says: - **Colour carries character and emotion.** Imaishi (director): small differences in age and clothing texture vanish in 2D animation, so **characters are told apart mainly by colour**. There are **no rules for rim-light colours; they're matched to the scene's emotion**. The high-contrast palette came out of *Promare* (Shigeto Koyama's colour design). - **Motion:** in the famous slow-motion sequences, each frame of a movement is drawn and **tinted a different colour**, spreading the frames out to stretch time. - **Design:** Yoh Yoshinari's designs are deliberately cartoon-ish and stylish. In his words, the look is "associated with very retro anime". A large library of hand-drawn effects animation does the heavy lifting. - The neon identity leans on a **loud yellow / magenta / cyan** scheme.

Our rules for characters: 1. **Silhouette first.** Each character is built on one dominant shape and readable as a black fill at 64 px tall:

CHARACTER	SHAPE	SIGNATURE COLOUR	SECONDARY
NIL	Tall rectangle + broken circle (the NaN halo, the coat)	Nixie orange `#FF7A2C`	Ink black, bone white
Vesper	Triangles (hat brim, coat tails, gun)	Crimson `#E5243B`	Black, brass
Maeve	Circles and arcs (braids, horseshoes)	Copper `#D9822B`	Clover green `#3BB273`
Hina	Dome (the umbrella) on a small body	Vermilion `#E34234`	Indigo `#26428B`
Tamamo	Fan and crescent (tails)	Violet `#8E44AD`	Gold `#F4C430`
Varro	Square block	Rust `#B7410E`	Gunmetal
Thale	Cathedral arch	Steel white `#E8E6E1`	Brass `#B5A642`

2. **Proportions:** lean and long-legged (about 7.5–8 heads), small heads, angular jaws and wrists, big readable hands. Faces are simple: clean eye shapes, no glossy multi-highlight eyes, small nose and mouth marks.
3. **Cel shading: base + one shadow tone** with hard edges, plus **one hard rim light** whose colour follows the emotion (Imaishi's rule): orange for resolve, cyan for cold fear, magenta for danger, gold for luck. No airbrush.
4. **Lineart:** coloured lines (dark wine on skin, deep navy on clothes), thicker on the outside silhouette and thinner inside; slightly tapered, as if inked.
5. **Expressions are big.** Trigger-style exaggeration for comedy and shock, then calm, still drawing for sincere moments (the Ghibli half).
6. **Costume logic:** every costume detail is a story detail (NIL's ledger clasps, Vesper's 7-chamber cylinder, Maeve's three braids, Hina's numbered kimono). If it isn't story, cut it.

Our rules for action and effects: 1. **Limited animation, strong timing:** key poses on 2s and 3s, holds before payoffs, **smear frames** on fast moves. 2. **Hand-drawn FX** with hard shapes: angular sparks, chunky smoke with flat shadow, speed lines, debris silhouettes. 3. **Impact frames:** 1–2 frames of inverted or two-colour flat graphics (black and the attacker's signature colour) on every big hit. 4. **The colour-step slow-mo** (each frame a different hue) is reserved for **Overwrite and Jackpot** moments, our version of the famous sequence. 5. **Glitch, chromatic aberration and scanlines appear only in Noise and Basilica moments**, never as a default filter. 6. Neon accent triad for combat and Meridian: **acid yellow** `#F5E400`**, hot magenta** `#FF2E88`**, cyan** `#00E5FF`, used as light, never as fill for whole areas.

3. Composition and camera

- **Exploration and story:** wide, calm, eye-level or slightly low; characters small in big painted spaces; long holds. Let the world breathe.
- **Combat:** tighter; low angles, Dutch tilts on hits, foreshortened limbs toward camera, diagonal staging; crash zooms on ultimates.
- **Cut-ins:** flat graphic panels in the character's signature colour with halftone or speed-line texture; one bold diagonal.
- **Readability:** fighters on the left, enemy on the right, reel top-centre, floor clear.

4. Colour script by land

LAND	DEFAULT TIME AND LIGHT	BASE PALETTE	ACCENT	NEON INTRUSION
Meridian Undercity	Rainy dusk → night; dawn for the intro	Wet slate blues, warm window ambers, moss greens	Nixie orange	**Full**: yellow, magenta, cyan signage
Hyakki (Japan-inspired)	Summer night, full moon; festival lanterns	Deep indigo, ink blue, paper cream	Vermilion, lantern gold, firefly green	Only Tamamo's foxfire (cold cyan-violet)
River Empire (China-inspired)	Golden afternoon over the harbour; misty underworld	Jade, warm ochre, red lacquer	Gold leaf	Luck Exchange boards
Śūnyapura (India-inspired)	Monsoon break: wet stone, sun through cloud	Sandstone, peacock green, saffron	Brass	Eclipse purple during Rahu & Ketu
Kroton Nova (Greece-inspired)	Hard Mediterranean noon	Chalk white, Aegean blue, olive	Bronze	The Sieve's cold white glow
Crossroads (America-inspired)	Desert sunset → neon night	Rust, sage, dusk violet	Sunset orange	Casino neon (full)
The Basilica	Interior, no sun	Brass and steel greys	Nixie orange	Total, until the finale's sunrise

5. Production pipeline (how we get polish, not just pictures)

1. **Colour script first:** one thumbnail per land and beat before any final art.
2. **Style frames:** 3–4 frames that define the look (a character key art, a painted establishing shot, a battle frame). Nothing scales up until they're approved.
3. **Characters are generated on a flat neutral background**, never inside a scene, so they stay cel-like and cut out cleanly.
4. **Backgrounds are generated as empty plates**, then split into parallax layers.
5. **Compositing happens in engine**: characters get rim light from the background's light colour; grade the whole frame per land.
6. **Paint-over pass** against the checklist below. AI output is a draft, never final.
7. **Animation:** rigs for idles (breathing, hair, cloth), drawn key poses + smears for attacks, hand-made FX.

QC checklist (every image)

- [ ] Silhouette reads as a black fill at thumbnail size
- [ ] Signature colour is the most saturated thing on the character
- [ ] Characters: 2 tones + 1 rim; no airbrush; coloured variable-weight lines
- [ ] Background: one light source, a time of day, atmospheric depth, 2–3 deliberate "little things"
- [ ] Neon only where the fiction allows it
- [ ] No stray text, no warped digits, correct hands, correct prop handedness
- [ ] Culture details checked against the World Bible §10

6. Prompt grammar for Higgsfield (replaces the old style suffix)

Describe the **medium and technique**, not "premium anime key art". Studio names are used here only as a team reference; in prompts we describe traits.

Character suffix:

> 2D cel animation character design, flat colours, hard-edged two-tone cel shading with a single hard rim light in {emotion colour}, crisp variable-weight coloured lineart (thick outer contour, thin interior lines), bold graphic silhouette, lean stylised proportions, retro-modern TV anime look, saturated limited palette dominated by {signature colour}, plain flat light-grey

> background, no gradients on skin or clothes, no airbrush, no glossy highlights, no 3D render, no text

Background suffix:

> hand-painted animation background, gouache / poster-colour painting on paper, soft wet-edge gradients in the sky, visible soft brushwork, limited harmonious palette, one clear light source ({time of day}), atmospheric perspective, warm lived-in details, nature growing over everything, painted in the tradition of classic Japanese animated films, no characters, no text, no photo texture, no 3D render

Battle-frame suffix:

> frame from a 2D anime fight scene: flat cel-shaded characters with bold coloured outlines over a hand-painted gouache background, {neon accent} light from the action, hand-drawn angular effects animation, speed lines, dynamic diagonal composition, no text

7. Reference library (study, never trace or copy)

- **Painted worlds:** *Kiki's Delivery Service* (a sunlit port town), *Spirited Away* (the bathhouse town at dusk), *Howl's Moving Castle* (rooftop towns), *Castle in the Sky* (skies and clouds), *The Boy and the Heron*; Kazuo Oga's background art books.
- **Inked action:** *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners*; *Promare* (high-contrast colour design); *Akira* (neon, light trails); *Mob Psycho 100* (effects animation).
- **Games doing this well:** *Ni no Kuni* (a game made with Studio Ghibli's animation), *Guilty Gear Strive* (3D that animates on 2s like 2D), *Hi-Fi Rush* (cel shading and timing), *Zenless Zone Zero* (urban anime and UI), *Sable* (Moebius-style flat colour), *Hades II* (painterly 2D characters with strong silhouettes), *Persona 5* (graphic UI).
- **Engine reference:** Epic's write-up on *Orbitals* (retro-anime cel shading quantised to about three tones, with noise to fake hand-painting).

8. Lessons from *The Official Digital Artbook of Cyberpunk 2077*

Studied from the 61-page digital art book (styles chapter, district spreads, character line-ups). We take its **methods**, not its look. Night City's yellow-and-black trade dress, logos and designs stay theirs.

8.1 What the book teaches

1. **Every style is grounded in the world's history.** CD PROJEKT RED wanted styles that are "interesting, colorful, distinctive and, most importantly of all, plausible". Wars, crises and booms each leave "a logical and perceivable impact" on design. Four eras coexist on the same street: *Kitsch* ("style over substance", street rebellion), *Entropism* ("necessity over style", poverty, crude and durable), *Neomilitarism* ("substance over style", cold corporate elegance) and *Neokitsch* ("style and substance", the ultra-rich: gold, real wood, natural fur).
2. **A visible design system.** The "Comparison" spread draws the same character type, phone and drink in each style, so artists and players can tell the eras apart at a glance.
3. **Districts are mixes of styles, and travelling should feel like changing countries.** "When traveling between them, you should feel as if you're visiting different countries." And: "above all Night City is about contrasts."
4. **Lived-in logic.** In Little China, people live whole lives in one repurposed office building: they sleep on the balcony, repair limbs in a supply closet and cook in a former office kitchen. In Kabuki, "Far East meets Wild West", with low shacks that let the sun through. Every space answers *who lives here, and what happened to this place?*
5. **Status through scarcity.** In North Oak, "green is the new gold": a bonsai on a balcony is a luxury watch.

6. **Contrast as storytelling.** Pacifica's abandoned resort pairs "funhouse signs riddled with bullet holes" with "luxury pools filled with chemical sludge".
7. **Graphic identity is part of the art.** The book's pages are one loud base colour with black type, overlaid with spray-paint tags, marker crosses, stickers and collage, so the presentation itself feels like the street.

8.2 Applied to the Tally: Meridian's four eras of luck

Meridian gets its own history-grounded style system, built on our lore (the Basilica, the Rounding, the Deficit). Each era has a motto, materials and its own way of **showing your Omen**, because in our world the number is the status symbol.

ERA	MOTTO	WHO	MATERIALS AND SHAPES	HOW THE OMEN IS SHOWN
Charmpunk (street)	*Luck over sense*	Gamblers, kids, gangs, small shops	Every culture's charms worn at once, hand-painted lucky numbers, plastic gold, neon, stickers	Gaudy holo-halos, numbers painted on jackets, fake Omen projectors
Remainder (poverty)	*Survival over luck*	The Undercity, the Settled	Scrap brass from old Basilica parts, patched cloth, salvaged Nixie tubes, rope	A cracked tube on a cord; often hidden out of shame
Ledgerism (power)	*Order over chance*	The Basilica, Auditors, Collectors	Brass, steel, white enamel, cathedral arches, clockwork, uniforms	Steel numerals, stamped seals, never glowing
Gilded Fortune (the 99s elite)	*Fortune and order*	Old money, Exchange magnates	Real gold leaf, jade, living plants (in Meridian, **a garden is luck you can see**), silk	Embroidered or gold-leaf numerals, discreet

The comparison sheet: for each era, draw the same three things, *a person, a lucky charm and an Omen display*, side by side (in the manner of the book's Comparison spread). It's the first concept-art task for Meridian.

Districts of Meridian mix eras: the Remainder Wards (Remainder + Charmpunk), the Exchange (Gilded Fortune over Ledgerism), the Basilica Ring (pure Ledgerism), and the Charm Bazaar (pure Charmpunk, "every culture meets on one street").

8.3 Applied to the other lands

Each land has its **own traditional style** (the painted world, §2.1). **Meridian's eras intrude** wherever the Basilica's influence reaches: Ledgerist toll gates on a Hyakki shrine road, Charmpunk stalls in Bāfā's festival, Remainder shanties under Kroton Nova's sieve. Those collisions are where our "contrast storytelling" lives.

8.4 Graphic identity (menus, title, marketing)

Borrow the **energy**, not the trade dress: one confident base colour, heavy type, hand-made overlays. - **Our base:** ledger-paper cream `#F2E8D5` with ink black `#141018` and Nixie orange `#FF7A2C`. Not Cyberpunk yellow. - **Overlays:** lucky-charm stickers, hand-stamped ledger seals, red-ink corrections and tally marks (𝍸), ink brush strokes from the lands, and spray tags for Charmpunk screens. - Every land's map, menus and cut-ins use that land's medium for overlays (woodblock stamps in Hyakki, gold leaf in Bāfā, palm-leaf script in Śūnyapura).

Sources

- What Kazuo Oga Thinks About When He Thinks About Backgrounds (Animation Obsessive)
- Painting in Ghibli style (Gurney Journey)
- Kazuo Oga's painting process (Open Culture)
- Roundtable interview: Imaishi and Wakabayashi, Anime NYC 2025 (Yattatachi)
- Reddit AMA recap: Hiroyuki Imaishi (Bubbleblabber)
- A pair of conversations with Studio Trigger (Anime Herald)
- Cyberpunk: Edgerunners, a vibrant ode to retro anime (AWN)
- Review of *The Art of Cyberpunk: Edgerunners* (Reframe)
- Rendering of Orbitals, a retro-anime-inspired game (Unreal Engine tech blog)
- *The Official Digital Artbook of Cyberpunk 2077* (CD PROJEKT RED, 2020; cyberpunk.net/artbook), provided by the team as a PDF and studied for §8. Not stored in this repo.

Motion tests

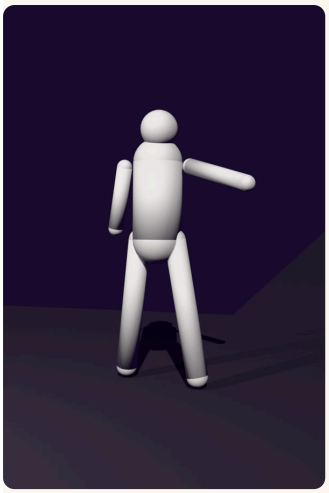


Intro shot 5 (8 s): the Basilica's searchlight sweeps the Undercity at dawn. Seedance 2.5 test.



NIL reveal (5 s, vertical). Seedance 2.5 test; inherits the "Nan" typo from pass 1.

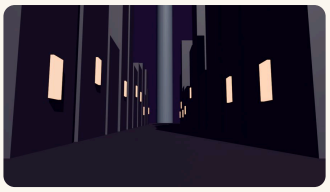
3D layouts used to keep framing consistent



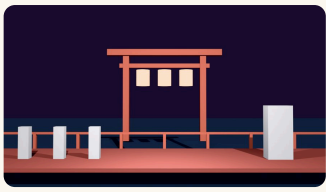
Standing pose layout



Action pose layout (v2)



Establishing-shot layout



Battle-stage layout

PART VII

Gameplay

One verb, deep consequences.



> *"Every number in this world is spinning. You're the only one who can stop them."*

An anime 2.5D party RPG across lands inspired by **Japanese, Chinese, Indian, Greek and American** myth and folklore. Every number spins like a slot reel, and you **tap to stop it**. Travel with NIL and two of eight companions, build Balatro-style synergies between heroes, charms and wheel faces, and break the Seals on the road to the Comptroller.

- Story, world and characters: `WORLD_BIBLE.md`
- Phases, schedule, art/animation pipeline: `PRODUCTION_PLAN.md`
- Higgsfield prompt pack: `../art/HIGGSFIELD_PROMPTS.md`
- Feel prototype (core verb only): `../prototype/index.html`

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0. Pillars (in priority order)

1. **Anime spectacle drives the game.** Cut-ins, camera, animation and motion graphics *are* the feedback. Every system pays out in something you watch.
2. **One verb, deep consequences.** Stop the number. Everything else (who acts, what's on your wheels, which charms you carry, who's in your party) changes *what that one action can do*.
3. **Complexity is earned, one land at a time.** Each land's culture contributes the system it is famous for (§5). The game starts with one wheel and ends with a team-synergy engine.
4. **Diegetic first.** Omen (HP) floats over heads; the reel is an in-world object styled per land; menus are in-world objects.
5. **The theme is the math, and the math is multicultural.** Lucky numbers and superstitions from every land drive story, mechanics and team-building. Theme counts double in jam judging.

---

1. Core combat (the Audit)

1.1 One round

1. **Your three strikes.** Tap a hero (or press 1/2/3) to choose who strikes next. Their **Fate Wheel** appears overhead: tens fixed, the ones digit spinning. **Tap to stop.** The hero attacks (cut-in, dash, hit-stop), and the stopped digit tears off the damage number and slams into the **reel** (3 tubes). - Party of 1: NIL strikes 3 times. Party of 2: choose an order, and one hero strikes twice. Party of 3: each strikes once.
2. **The reel resolves** into a pattern that multiplies the round (§1.3), with a full-screen cinematic.
3. **The enemy strikes.** Its wheel spins over it. Stop on **0** to parry, on your lucky digit to reflect; anything else hurts.

1.2 The number (chips × mult, made visible)

```
Strike value  = Tens (hero level + gear) + Digit stopped + face bonus
Round damage  = (Σ strike values + flat bonuses)  ×  Mult
Mult          = Pattern mult (+ gem levels)  + additive mult (charms, faces)  then  × each ×Mult charm
```

Strikes land as small white numbers; then the pattern title slams in and a **× Mult** counts up into one huge gold number. That gives a small payoff every 3 seconds and a big one every round.

Design rule: tens are safe, ones are fate. Anything that adds to the tens never changes the digit you stopped.

1.3 Reel patterns

PATTERN	EXAMPLE	BASE MULT	EXTRA	CINEMATIC
Bust	2-9-5	×1	—	Tubes flicker out
Pair	7-1-7	×2	—	Small flourish

PATTERN	EXAMPLE	BASE MULT	EXTRA	CINEMATIC
Zero-Sum	3-3-4 (sums to 10/20)	×2	Enemy's next action cancelled	Mirror wipe, ledger chime
Cascade	3-4-5, 9-8-7	×3	Extra round (the enemy waits)	Time-slow bands
Jackpot	7-7-7	×digit (min ×2)	—	Squad panels slash down, screen crack
Omen Overwrite	your digit ×3	×3·digit	Charges every ultimate	Gold everything; bells ring your number of times
Reaper's Toll	4-4-4	×4	Every Omen containing a 4 loses 44%, **yours included**	Four bells toll, red wash

1.4 Defence

The enemy's wheel shows its odds by cell size. **0 → Parry** (no damage, counter flash); **your digit → Fortune** (reflect); otherwise take tens + digit. Some enemies (the Prime Synod) have no 0 on their wheel, so the party must win the race instead.

1.5 Wheels show the odds

A wheel is a strip of **faces**, and a face's height is its odds. Players read probability by looking.

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2. The party

NIL plus 2 of 8 companions. Swap at a Teahouse / Campfire node or before a boss.

2.1 What every hero has

Fate Wheel (speed + faces) · base tens · a passive · an **ultimate** (charged when their digit lands three times or by an Overwrite) · a synergy digit · an **Awakening** (Act IV, one of two class branches) · a **bond arc** (4 scenes).

2.2 Roster kits

HERO	DIGIT	LAND	WHEEL	PASSIVE	ULTIMATE
NIL	yours	—	Medium; your digit double-wide; **Splice** (tens *and* ones wheels)	Grows by act (§6)	*Remainder Release*: the reel gains a 4th tube this round
Vesper Sette	7	Meridian / Crossroads	Fast	*Lucky Seven*: each 7 on the reel adds +7 to every strike this round	*Seven-Chamber Requiem*: 7 rapid auto-stopping mini-wheels; each 7 doubles the shot
Maeve Triskel	3	Meridian (Celtic quarter)	Medium; has **Horseshoe** faces	*Third Time Lucky*: the round's 3rd strike counts double if Maeve made it; she upgrades charms at forge nodes	*Triskele*: three spinning horseshoes each land a free 3 on the reel (an instant Jackpot of 3s, or a Twins pattern with NIL 3)
Hina of the Ninety-Nine	9	Hyakki	Bouncy: it reverses direction at random	*Ninety-Nine*: 9s don't curse her party; each 9 landed gives +9 Mult while her Omen is 99 or below… which it always is	*Hundred-Year Night*: her umbrella opens with one eye; for one round every wheel shows only the party's lucky digits
Ba Jinling	8	River Empire	Slow; 8 double-wide; Gold faces	*Compound*: +0.8 Mult per consecutive patterned round	*Eight Bells*: ×1.1 Mult per bell (×2.14) and +8 coins each
Bai Si	4	River Empire	Medium; 4 triple-wide	*Fourfold*: every 4th strike of a fight marks the enemy (×1.44 damage taken)	*Four Lanterns Out*: Reaper's Toll that spares the party
Shunya	0	Śūnyapura	Slow; 0 triple-wide	*Pūrṇa (fullness)*: 0s on the reel are wild for every pattern	*Place Value*: move any reel digit into the tens of every strike next round (×10 its weight)
Prima of Kroton	2	Kroton Nova	Only 2-3-5-7 plus one 0	*Indivisible*: prime strikes pierce armour; +1 Mult per prime on the reel	*Sieve of Light*: shatter every composite number on screen (enemy shields and armour)

HERO	DIGIT	LAND	WHEEL	PASSIVE	ULTIMATE
Fibi Leone	Fibonacci	Crossroads	Her lucky digit **advances every round** (1, 1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 3, 1…)	*Golden Ratio*: Cascades give ×1.618; Fibonacci triples count as Cascade	*Spiral Deal*: the reel extends to 5 tubes this round (Full House, Five-Run…)

2.3 Synergy is number theory (no trait UI)

Bonds come from the **relationships between lucky digits**. The party screen draws constellation lines between digits, and that's the whole interface.

BOND	RULE	EFFECT	EXAMPLE COMPS (CROSS-CULTURAL ON PURPOSE)
Complements	Digits sum to 10	Zero-Sum becomes ×4 and triggers a **Link Art**	Vesper 7 + Maeve 3 · Ba 8 + Prima 2 · Hina 9 + Fibi (on 1) · Bai Si 4 + NIL 6
Neighbours	Consecutive digits	Two-digit runs count as a Cascade	Vesper 7 + Ba 8 · Ba 8 + Hina 9 · Prima 2 + Maeve 3 · Maeve 3 + Bai Si 4
Twins	Same digit (NIL chose a companion's digit)	That digit's Jackpot ×2, plus a shared ultimate gauge	NIL 7 + Vesper
Prime Party	All three digits prime	Every strike pierces; Prime Trio pattern unlocked (×5)	Prima 2 + Maeve 3 + Vesper 7
Powers of Two	Digits are 1/2/4/8	Each pattern doubles next round's mult	Prima 2 + Bai Si 4 + Ba 8
Śūnya	Shunya in the party	0 is wild for every bond above	Shunya + anyone
Old World / New World	One hero from an "old ledger" land + one from Meridian/Crossroads	Charms from both lands' sets count for each other's set bonuses	Hina + Vesper, Prima + Fibi

Why it's deep: the player picks NIL's number in the opening minute, before knowing any of this, and that quietly decides who completes NIL all game. Pick 3 and Vesper is your Complement; pick 1 and it's Hina; pick 6 and only Bai Si completes you.

2.4 Link Arts (duo anime cinematics)

Every Complement and Neighbour pair has a 3–5 s combination attack that blends both heroes' **art styles**: - **Vesper + Maeve, *Lucky Strike*:** Maeve hurls a burning horseshoe; Vesper shoots it in mid-air into seven ricochets. - **Ba + Prima, *Golden Sieve*:** coins pour through Prima's shield as golden spears; gongbi gold meets Greek marble. - **Hina + Vesper, *Midnight Parade*:** ukiyo-e yokai stampede through a Western saloon door. - **Bai Si + Shunya, *Zero Count*:** lanterns go out one by one and the observatory's sundial shadow cuts the enemy.

These are the trailer moments and the reward for team-building.

3. Build systems (the Balatro layer), and the land each comes from

SYSTEM	BALATRO ANALOGUE	WHAT IT IS	LAND THAT TEACHES IT
Charms of the World	Jokers	Lucky charms from every culture; slots 3 → 6; ordered left to right	Hyakki (shrine charms, *omamori*)
Wheel crafting	Deck building + enhancements	Remove, duplicate or enhance faces on each wheel	River Empire (the Luck Exchange)
Oracle sticks (求签)	Tarot cards	Shake the cylinder and a fortune stick falls: a one-shot effect with a fortune poem	River Empire
Ink (the Judge's Brush)	Spectral cards	Rewrite one reel digit after it lands	River Empire (Ten Courts)
Karma	—	A resource banked by parries and Zero-Sums, spent to re-spin or to block a lethal hit	Śūnyapura
Navaratna gems (the nine planetary gems)	Planet cards	Permanently level up a pattern (Ruby → Jackpot, Pearl → Pair, Emerald → Cascade…)	Śūnyapura

SYSTEM	BALATRO ANALOGUE	WHAT IT IS	LAND THAT TEACHES IT
Awakenings (the Moirai's thread)	—	Each hero picks one of two class branches	Kroton Nova
Crossroads Deals	Risky vouchers	A powerful boon with a price ("+2 charm slots, but your Omen max is 77")	Crossroads
Wagers	Stakes	Bet coins or Omen before a fight for bigger rewards	Crossroads
Omen Levels	Stakes	Difficulty tiers 1–8	Post-game

3.1 Charms of the World (jam needs 12, full game ~90)

Organised in **sets by land**. Holding several from one set grants a set bonus, so collecting is a build axis.

CHARM	SET	RULE
Beckoning Cat (*maneki-neko*)	Hyakki	+1 coin per strike ending in your digit
Daruma	Hyakki	When you land your digit three times in a fight, paint the second eye: ×2 Mult for the rest of the fight
Seven Lucky Gods (7 charms: Ebisu, Daikokuten, Bishamonten, Benzaiten, Fukurokuju, Jurōjin, Hotei)	Hyakki	Each has a small effect; holding all 7 makes every 7 a Jackpot by itself
Ofuda ward	Hyakki	The first enemy strike each fight is parried
Red Envelope (红包)	River Empire	+8 coins on a Jackpot
Door God (门神)	River Empire	Parries also deal the enemy's strike back
Peach-Wood Sword (桃木剑)	River Empire	×2 Mult vs ghosts and Noiselings
Lemon and Seven Chillies (*nimbu-mirchi*)	Śūnyapura	Cancels one enemy curse per fight; +7 tens per 7 on the reel
108 Beads	Śūnyapura	Every 108th point of damage in a round counts double (rewards huge numbers)
Evil-Eye Bead (*mati*)	Kroton Nova	The enemy's wheel shows its next digit faintly
Fortuna's Wheel	Kroton Nova	Once per fight, spin the reel itself: all three digits re-roll
Owl Coin	Kroton Nova	+1 Mult per prime strike
Horseshoe	Crossroads	Your digit's cells are 50% wider
Rabbit's Foot	Crossroads	One free re-spin per fight
Lucky Penny	Crossroads	+1 coin when you land a 1
Seven-Come-Eleven Dice	Crossroads	If a round's strikes total 7 or 11 (or 70/110/700…), ×7 Mult
Four-Leaf Clover	Meridian (Celtic)	1-in-4 chance per strike to duplicate its digit on the reel
Thirteenth Floor	Meridian	×13 Mult if the round total ends in 13
Black Cat	Meridian	The first Bust each fight becomes a Pair

3.2 Wheel crafting (faces)

Remove · Duplicate · Enhance: **Gold** (+3 coins) · **Jade** (+4 Mult) · **Glass** (×2 strike; 1-in-4 chance it shatters) · **Iron** (+20 tens while *not* stopped) · **Lantern** (the wheel slows passing it) · **Ink** (wild) · **Horseshoe** (Maeve: lands as your digit 1 time in 4) · **Cursed** (+50 tens, curses the striker). Every enhancement is visible on the wheel itself.

3.3 Economy

Coins come from fights (with interest: 1 per 5 held, capped), charms and gold faces. They buy charms, sticks, gems, crafting and rerolls at Markets.

4. Structure: acts, levels and bosses

4.1 An act is a map of ~8 nodes ending in a boss

The map is an in-world object in the land's style: a hand-scroll (Hyakki, River Empire), a palm-leaf manuscript (Śūnyapura), a mosaic floor (Kroton Nova), a frontier road map (Crossroads).

NODE	PURPOSE
Small Audit / Big Audit	Fights
Elite / **Keeper's Trial**	Hard fight with a special rule; Keepers are revered figures who test you (Enma, Judge Cui, Chitragupta, the Moirai)
Market	Charms, sticks, gems, crafting
Shrine / Forge	Free charm or face enhancement (Maeve's forge upgrades charms)
Teahouse / Campfire	Swap party, bond scenes, rest
Story	Cutscene + choice
Boss Audit	The land's Auditor and its unique rule

Each act ≈ 25–35 minutes. The full campaign ≈ 6–8 hours.

4.2 Difficulty curve (exponential, like Balatro's blinds)

ACT	SMALL / BIG / BOSS TARGET OMEN
Prologue (Meridian)	300 / 500 / 1,200
I (Hyakki)	1,500 / 2,500 / 6,000
II (River Empire)	8,000 / 14,000 / 35,000
III (Śūnyapura)	50k / 90k / 200k
IV (Kroton Nova)	300k / 600k / 1.5M
V (Crossroads)	2.5M / 5M / 12M
Finale	99,999,999 ("the whole Ledger")

Linear growth (tens) can't keep up past Act II. Players **must** build multiplier engines. Losing a fight returns you to the act start with the build you had there.

4.3 Bosses: each changes the rules

BOSS	RULE	COUNTER-PLAY IT TEACHES
Varro, the Ledgerhound	Steals your last reel digit into a debt jar; 3 parries shatter it	Defence matters
Tamamo, the Nine-Tailed	9 tails, each its own small Omen; foxfire **illusion faces** on your wheels (show one digit, land as another); 9s curse you unless Hina is in the party	Read carefully; the Hina synergy
Jin Chan, the Golden Toad	His Omen gains interest each round; taxes your Jackpots; phase 2 swallows a hero (land a Pair to free them)	Burst damage; economy
Rahu & Ketu, the Eclipse	Two bodies: Rahu darkens one reel tube each round; Ketu strikes with a blind random wheel; if their Omens drift >10% apart they rejoin and heal	**Balance damage between two targets**: Zero-Sum hits both equally
Archon Seventeen	Strikes digits off *your* wheels each round (Sieve of Eratosthenes); composite strikes halved	Wheel crafting; Prima's primes
The House	Rewinds time every 3 rounds (your reel and charms persist); copies your last pattern; offers a mid-fight deal	Finish within one loop; read the deal
Comptroller Thale	P1 Regression to the Mean · P2 Fixed Fate (wheels don't spin: a puzzle) · P3 Zero (NIL alone; companions return as Link Arts)	Everything

4.4 Variability

Enemy pools per land with distinct wheels (kasa-obake wheels hop; Golden Koi multiply when hit; Vetālas ask a riddle and the answer is a digit; Harpies steal a reel tube; the Headless Horseman's wheel has no top half). Random charm, gem and stick offers; branching maps; Elite modifiers ("Noise storm: all wheels reversed"). Party composition: 28 companion pairs × 10 NIL digits. Post-game **Endless Ledger**: every land shuffled into a true roguelike, Omen Levels 1–8, and a Daily Omen seed.

5. The complexity ladder (each land teaches what its culture is known for)

WHEN	NEW	TAUGHT BY
Prologue, fight 1	Stop the wheel; reel; Jackpot/Pair/Bust; Parry	NIL alone vs Debt Hounds
Prologue, fight 2	Choose who strikes; hero wheels differ; Cascade, Zero-Sum	Vesper joins
Prologue, boss	Ultimates	Vesper's Requiem saves NIL
Act I, Hyakki	**Charms** (3 slots) and charm sets; curses (4 *shi*, 9 *ku*); Reaper's Toll; **party of 3, bonds, Link Arts**	The Seven Lucky Gods' shrine; Hina joins
Act II, River Empire	**Coins, Markets, wheel crafting, oracle sticks, Ink**	The Luck Exchange; Judge Cui's Brush
Act III, Śūnyapura	**Karma; Navaratna gems (pattern levels)**; NIL's **Ledger Tree**	Chitragupta's Hall; Shunya
Act IV, Kroton Nova	**Awakenings**; number properties (prime, perfect 6 and 28, golden ratio)	The Moirai's three trials
Act V, Crossroads	**Crossroads Deals; Wagers; loops**	The midnight crossroads
Finale	Everything, then taken away	Thale freezes your wheels
Post-game	Endless Ledger, Omen Levels, Daily Omen	—

6. NIL's growth (the most important progression)

ACT	VERB	WHAT IT DOES	WHY THIS LAND
Prologue	**Splice**	Two wheels (tens and ones) for high-control strikes	NIL's own nature
I	**Carry**	A strike over 50 carries +1 to the next hero's digit	Learned from Hina's century of counting
II	**Rewrite**	Free Ink each fight (rewrite one reel digit)	The Judge's Brush
III	**Place Value**	Move one stopped digit into the tens place of the next strike	India's place-value system
IV	**Factor**	Split one strike into two reel digits (56 → 7 and 8)	Greek number theory
V	**Deal**	Once per fight, take a Crossroads Deal mid-battle	The black book
Finale	**Divide by Zero**	Ultimate: NIL's digit is wild on every wheel for a round	Everything

The **Ledger Tree** (from Act III) has one branch per Seal (7), with 3–4 nodes each, fed by recovered memory digits. Examples: *Remainder +1* (permanent 4th reel tube, late), *Audit Eye* (see the enemy's next wheel), *Compound Remainder* (+Mult per Settled enemy this act).

7. Hero progression

- **Levels** (shared XP): +10 tens per level (digits never change). Cap 30.
- **Bond arcs:** 4 scenes per hero → second passive, Link Art upgrade, true-ending flag.
- **Awakening** (Act IV): one of two class branches per hero (e.g. Vesper: *Dead Man's Hand* crits vs *Blackjack* bonus at 21; Hina: *Hundred Years* becomes real vs *Kasa-obake* stays a trickster).
- **Gear:** one personal charm slot per hero.

8. Minimal UI, still

SCREEN	IN-WORLD OBJECT
Combat	Diorama + land-styled reel: neon sign (Meridian) · torii with three hanging lanterns (Hyakki) · golden abacus (River Empire) · observatory sundial dials (Śūnyapura) · three marble columns with mosaic numerals (Kroton Nova) · slot machine (Crossroads) · Basilica clock (Meridian)
Map	Scroll / palm-leaf / mosaic / road map, by land
Market	A stall with wares on the table
Teahouse / Campfire	Heroes sit around; drag two beside NIL; constellation lines show bonds
Charms	Pinned to the reel frame, left to right
Lucky-number choice	The Naming terminal: ten Nixie tubes

9. Jam slice scope (ships Nov 13)

"Prologue & Act I: The Remainder and the Night Parade": the intro cinematic (a five-culture montage), the Prologue (Meridian Undercity, 3 nodes + Varro) and Act I (Hyakki, ~6 nodes + Tamamo), then an ending cinematic teasing the River Empire and Thale.

SYSTEM	IN THE JAM SLICE
Core verb, reel, all 7 patterns, parry	✅
Heroes	NIL + Vesper (7) + Maeve (3) + Hina (9): choose 2 of 3 in Act I
Bonds / Link Arts	Complements, Neighbours, Twins; Link Art *Lucky Strike* (Vesper + Maeve) and *Midnight Parade* (Hina + Vesper)
Ultimates	✅ every hero
Charms	12: Hyakki set (beckoning cat, daruma, ofuda, 3 of the Seven Lucky Gods) + Meridian/Crossroads (horseshoe, rabbit's foot, black cat, four-leaf clover, thirteenth floor, seven-come-eleven); 3 slots
Wheel crafting	Remove + Gold/Jade/Glass at one Hyakki shrine; Maeve's forge upgrades a charm
NIL verbs	Splice + Carry
Bosses	Varro, Tamamo (nine tails, foxfire illusions)
Keeper's Trial	Enma (optional elite)
Not in jam	Economy beyond coins, oracle sticks, Ink, Karma, gems, Awakenings, Acts II–V

10. Build & tech summary

Unity 6 LTS · URP · WebGL 2 (WebGPU optional) · Unity 2D Animation (PSB rigs) + Cinemachine 3 + Timeline + PrimeTween · VideoPlayer for cinematic clips from StreamingAssets · pure C# rules core with EditMode tests · ScriptableObject data for heroes, wheels, faces, charms (with set tags), enemies, boss rules and maps. Details in `PRODUCTION_PLAN.md` §5.

PART VIII

Production

From jam slice to full game.



How we get from today (Fri 6 Nov 2026, jam day 1) to a polished jam slice by **Fri 13 Nov**, then to a full game. Read with `GDD.md` and `WORLD_BIBLE.md`.

Hard jam deadline: Sat 14 Nov 2026, 12:00 UTC. A WebGL build is required. AI use must be disclosed (log it in `AI_DISCLOSURE.md` as you go).

1. Reality check

The full vision (a capital plus five lands inspired by Japanese, Chinese, Indian, Greek and American myth; 9 playable heroes; ~30 enemies; 7 bosses; 5 keeper trials; 4 endings; ~20 minutes of cinematics) is a **12–15 month** production for a small team. In 7 days the right move is a **vertical slice** that looks finished. Make a short game that feels like the opening of a AAA anime RPG, not a long game that looks like a jam game. The jam judges and players will see 20–30 minutes; make every one of them look like the trailer.

APPROACH	VERDICT
All 7 acts, rough	❌ Loses on art, polish and cohesion
Intro + Prologue + Act I, polished, ending on a cliffhanger	✅ Wins on theme (lucky number in the first minute), art, narrative and fun
Intro + Prologue only	✅ Fallback if the team is 1–2 people

2. Phases

PHASE	DATES	GOAL	EXIT CRITERIA
0 · Pre-production & look-dev	Fri 6 Nov (today)	Lock story, systems, style; prove the art pipeline	Bibles merged ✅ · style anchor image chosen · NIL key art approved · Unity WebGL "hello" build loads on a private itch page
1 · Jam vertical slice	Sat 7 – Fri 13 Nov	Ship *"Prologue & Act I: The Remainder and the Night Parade"*	Submitted, with disclosure, by Fri 13 Nov
1.5 · Jam rating	14 Nov – 10 Dec	No build changes (jam rule). Collect feedback; prep Steam page; R&D	Feedback log; Act II design locked; Steam page draft
2 · Demo: Acts 0–II	Dec 2026 – Mar 2027	The River Empire (Bāfā Harbor + the Ten Courts): economy, wheel crafting, oracle sticks, Ink; 6 heroes (+ Ba Jinling, Bai Si); NIL's *Rewrite*	Public demo for the next Steam Next Fest; trailer; wishlists
3 · Production: Acts III–V	Apr – Sep 2027	Śūnyapura (India-inspired), Kroton Nova (Greece-inspired), the Crossroads Territory (America-inspired); full roster of 8; Karma, Navaratna gems, Awakenings, Deals, Wagers, Ledger Tree; VO; localisation (Japanese, Chinese, Hindi); cultural reviewers per land	Content complete through Act V
4 · Finale, endgame, launch	Oct 2027 – Jan 2028	Meridian, 4 endings, Endless Ledger, Omen Levels, Daily Omen, QA	Launch on PC; mobile (the one-tap verb suits touch) after
5 · The Far Lands (post-launch)	2028	Expansion acts: Norse North (the Norns), Kemet (Ma'at's scales), the Long Count (Maya zero), Anansi's Coast (Akan folklore), the House of Wisdom (al-Khwārizmī), each with cultural consultants	One act per update

3. The jam slice (Phase 1) in detail

3.1 Content list

CATEGORY	ITEMS
Cinematics	Intro (≈2:30, World Bible §8, including the five-culture ledger montage) · Prologue end: world-map reveal with six lands in six art styles (≈30 s) · Act I end: Tamamo's question + Thale teaser (≈45 s) · 2 Link Arts (*Lucky Strike*, *Midnight Parade*, 4 s each) · ultimates for NIL, Vesper, Maeve, Hina (3 s each)
Playable heroes	**NIL** (Splice, Carry), **Vesper** (7, Prologue), **Maeve** (3, Prologue, optional), **Hina** (9, Act I): choose 2 of 3 in Act I

CATEGORY	ITEMS
Bosses	**Varro the Ledgerhound** (debt jar) · **Tamamo, the Nine-Tailed** (nine tails, foxfire illusion faces, the curse of 9) · Keeper's Trial: **Enma** (optional elite)
Enemies	Meridian: Debt Hound, Collector, Noiseling · Hyakki: Kasa-obake (umbrella spirit), Chōchin-obake (lantern ghost), Kappa, Oni enforcer
Regions	Meridian Undercity (battle stage + map) · Hyakki (2 battle stages: the red bridge of the Night Parade, Tamamo's foxfire palace; hand-scroll map) · Naming shrine (intro)
Systems	Everything in GDD §9: verb, reel, 7 patterns, parry, bonds (Complements/Neighbours/Twins), 12 Charms of the World incl. Hyakki set bonus (3 slots), shrine face crafting (Remove, Gold, Jade, Glass), Maeve's forge, ultimates
Audio	Meridian theme (synth noir), Hyakki theme (shamisen, shakuhachi and taiko over synth pads), Tamamo boss theme; every land later gets its own instrumentation (erhu/guzheng, sitar/tabla, lyre/bouzouki, slide guitar/harmonica); each in 4 stems that fill with the reel; SFX vocabulary; optional AI voice for the Basilica and Thale (disclose it)
Length	25–35 minutes

3.2 Team shape

SIZE	ROLES	SCOPE
5 (ideal)	Lead dev (combat/sequencing) · Dev 2 (UI, map, data, build) · Character artist/animator · Environment + VFX artist · Cinematics/audio/writing	Full slice
3	Dev · Art/animation · Cinematics/audio/design	Full slice, with 1 Link Art and enemies as 3-pose sprites
1–2	Everything	Intro + Prologue (NIL + Vesper + Maeve, Varro), then a "to be continued" Hyakki teaser

3.3 Day-by-day (all dates UTC)

DAY	DATE	CODE	CHARACTER ART & ANIMATION	ENVIRONMENTS & VFX	CINEMATICS, AUDIO, WRITING	EXIT TEST
1	Fri 6	Unity 6 project, URP, WebGL; **empty build on a private itch page**; port the prototype's rules to the C# `Core` with tests	Higgsfield look-dev: style anchor, **NIL key art**, Vesper, Maeve, Hina, Tamamo concepts (§4)	Meridian Undercity + Hyakki establishing concepts	Intro script and shot list final; temp music	Build loads on itch; style anchor chosen
2	Sat 7	Combat greybox with wheels, reel, patterns, parry, hero picking, scoring formula	NIL / Vesper / Maeve / Hina: turnarounds, expressions, **layered PSDs**	Meridian battle stage split into parallax layers; in-world neon reel	Intro storyboard frames (stills); generate intro video shots batch 1	A fight is fun with greybox art
3	Sun 8	Map scroll + nodes; talismans (ordered effect pipeline); bonds	**Rig** NIL / Vesper / Maeve / Hina (2D Animation); attack key poses ×3 each	Hyakki stages ×2 (layers); ukiyo-e woodblock VFX (flat wave and cloud shapes); torii-and-lantern reel	Intro shots batch 2; edit intro v1	Prologue playable start-to-finish
4	Mon 9	Ultimates and Link Arts (video + in-engine); NIL's Splice and Carry; enemy wheel profiles	Varro + Tamamo boss rigs (Tamamo's nine tails on spring bones); 7 enemies (3-pose sprite animation)	Land-styled cut-in bands (neon glitch vs woodblock print); hit sparks; foxfire	Ultimate clips; Link Art clips; music stems v1	Act I playable with placeholder bosses
5	Tue 10	Boss rules (debt jar; nine tails; foxfire illusion faces); shrine face crafting; Maeve's forge; Teahouse party select. **FEATURE FREEZE**	Secondary motion (hair/cloth springs), blinks, reactions to the reel	Lighting pass, post-processing, weather	Prologue-end (world map) + Act I-end cinematics; SFX pass	Full slice playable
6	Wed 11	Balance (wheel speeds, targets) with 5 playtests; WebGL perf + size. **CONTENT LOCK**	Polish poses, victory animations	Polish, optimisation (atlases, compression)	Final mix; subtitles; credits	60 fps; < 250 MB; no blockers
7	Thu 12	Bugs only; reduced-motion + assist modes; release candidate	Capture GIFs and screenshots	itch page art	AI disclosure finished; page copy	RC on the private page

DAY	DATE	CODE	CHARACTER ART & ANIMATION	ENVIRONMENTS & VFX	CINEMATICS, AUDIO, WRITING	EXIT TEST
Buffer	Fri 13	**Submit.** Rate your 3-game queue.				Submitted

4. Art pipeline with Higgsfield

4.1 What's available

NEED	HIGGSFIELD TOOL	NOTES
Character and environment stills	**3D Jutsu →** `generate_angles` (Seedream V5 Pro) from a blockout render; or the Higgsfield web app's image models (Nano Banana Pro, GPT Image 2.6, Seedream, Cinema Studio)	The blockout fixes pose and framing, which keeps the roster consistent
Consistent characters across images and videos	**Elements** (reusable reference characters/environments)	Create one per hero from the approved key art, then use it in every later prompt
Video cutscenes	**3D Jutsu →** `generate_video` (Seedance 2.5: text-to-video or start image), or the web app (Seedance 2.0, Kling 3.0 with a start frame, Cinema Studio Video 3.0)	720p, 4–30 s per clip; use start frames or Elements for consistency
Animated idle loops (optional)	Genjutsu motion presets on a character sheet	For dialogue portraits; check loop seams

Composition guides already rendered (free) in this repo: `art/lookdev/pose_blockout.png` (full-body hero pose, 2:3) and `art/lookdev/street_blockout.png` (deep street with a tower, 16:9). The 3D Jutsu project is **"ZERO-SUM OMEN - Look Dev"**.

4.2 Character pipeline (per hero, ~1 day for a 2D artist plus AI)

1. **Key art.** Use the 3D Jutsu pose blockout and the prompt from `art/HIGGSFIELD_PROMPTS.md`. Generate 4 variations and pick 1.
2. **Element.** Create a Higgsfield Element from the approved image (name it after the hero).
3. **Sheets.** Using the Element: front/side/back turnaround, 6 expressions, 3 attack key poses, hurt, victory, ultimate splash.
4. **Paint-over.** Fix hands, the costume's signature details (NIL's decoder is on the *right* wrist; Vesper's cylinder has 7 chambers) and the palette. This is where AI art becomes *our* art, and where coherence is won.
5. **Layer split.** Separate hair front/back, face, eyes, mouth, torso, arms, coat tails and weapon into a PSB (manual + segmentation tools; ~2–3 h).
6. **Rig.** Unity 2D Animation bones + mesh deformation (a Live2D-style idle: breathing, hair and coat on spring bones, blinks).
7. **Action.** Anime *limited animation*: snap between the 3 drawn key poses with smear frames, holds on 2s/3s, impact frames, VFX and camera. This is a genuine anime technique, not a shortcut, and it reads as high-end.
8. **Ultimate.** A 3–4 s video from the splash illustration (image-to-video), played full-screen.

Making characters feel alive: they **react to numbers**. Vesper grins and spins her cylinder when a 7 lands; Maeve kisses her clover on a 3; Hina's umbrella sticks out its tongue on a 9; Tamamo's tails flare when a 4 appears; everyone flinches on a Bust; idle barks reference the reel. Reaction poses are cheap, and they make the theme personal.

4.3 Environment pipeline (per stage, ~half a day)

1. Blockout in 3D Jutsu with the battle camera (heroes left, enemy right, reel object top-centre).
2. Generate the painting at 2k using the region's style prompt.
3. Split into 3–5 depth layers (depth estimation + inpaint the hidden areas).
4. In Unity: layered planes at depth, Cinemachine moves give real parallax; add particles (rain, mist, lanterns, joss paper, petals) and shader motion (water, flags, flicker).

4.4 Cinematic pipeline

1. Storyboard each shot as a still (image generation, same Elements).
2. Animate with Seedance 2.5 or Kling 3.0 from that still as the **start frame**, 5–10 s per shot, 720p.

3. Edit, then grade to the region palette, add sound design, music and subtitles.
4. Export H.264 720p; play via Unity `VideoPlayer` from `StreamingAssets` (WebGL plays video from a URL; audio is unlocked by the title-screen tap).
5. Mix video with in-engine shots: the Naming terminal choice and the logo slam must be in-engine so they use the player's digit.

4.5 Consistency rules (pin these up)

- Always reference the hero's **Element**, and append the **style suffix** from the prompt pack, unchanged.
- One palette per land; every hero keeps their signature colour (NIL orange-teal, Vesper crimson, Maeve copper-green, Hina red-white, Tamamo gold-violet foxfire, Varro rust).
- QC every image: hair streak, eye colour, signature prop, handedness, digit glyphs readable.
- Keep a log: every generation that ships goes in `AI_DISCLOSURE.md` (tool, model, what, how it was edited).

4.6 Credit budget

Paid generations spend Higgsfield credits. Rough counts for the slice: **~150–250 images** (including iterations) and **~35–45 video clips** (intro ~10, other cinematics ~10, ultimates/Link Arts ~6, iterations). Check current pricing in your Higgsfield plan before starting, and confirm commercial-use rights for your plan before any post-jam release.

5. Technical plan

AREA	DECISION
Engine	Unity 6 LTS (6000.3); WebGL 2 baseline (WebGPU optional on 6.6+ only if tested in every major browser)
Rendering	URP; 2D characters on lit quads (Shader Graph, alpha clip + rim light); baked or unlit painted backgrounds; Bloom/LUT/vignette/grain
Characters	Unity 2D Animation (PSB importer, bones, Sprite Skin), spring bones for hair and cloth
Camera & cutscenes	Cinemachine 3, Timeline, VideoPlayer (StreamingAssets URLs)
Tweening	PrimeTween
Code layout	`Core/` (pure C#: wheels, reel, patterns, scoring, bonds, talisman pipeline, deterministic RNG; EditMode tests) · `Sequencing/` (async beat scripts: HeroStrike, EnemyStrike, PatternPayoff, LinkArt, Ultimate) · `Data/` (ScriptableObjects: HeroDef, WheelDef, FaceDef, TalismanDef, EnemyDef, BossRuleDef, ActMapDef) · `Presentation/` · `Audio/` (stem controller, beat clock)
Save	PlayerPrefs (IndexedDB on web): act checkpoints, bonds, codex
WebGL budget	< 250 MB total; character atlases $\leq 2048^2$; Crunch compression; music streamed Vorbis; videos 720p H.264 at ~2.5 Mbps; Gzip with decompression fallback; first fight playable within 20 s of load
Accessibility	Reduced motion, assist (slower wheels), subtitles, colour-independent signals

The **rules core comes straight from the prototype** (`prototype/index.html`: wheel odds, pattern evaluation, round flow). Port it on Day 1 so art can land on working gameplay from Day 2.

6. Risks

RISK	LIKELIHOOD	MITIGATION
AI art inconsistency across poses/videos	High	Elements + paint-over + QC checklist; start frames for every video shot
Animation scope (rigs take longer than planned)	High	Limited-animation key poses; enemies as 3-pose sprites; cut Link Arts to 1
WebGL size and performance with high-res art and video	Medium	Budgets in §5; test the uploaded build daily from Day 1
Some community raters dislike visible AI art	Medium	Heavy paint-over on heroes; disclose honestly; let the hand-built motion, systems and writing carry the identity

RISK	LIKELIHOOD	MITIGATION
Cultural inaccuracy across five cultures	Medium–High	Reviewers from each culture (Japanese, Chinese, Indian, Greek, American) for names, scripts, clothing and terms; revered deities are keepers, never enemies; no Indigenous sacred material (World Bible §10)
Theme too buried under RPG systems	Low	The lucky-number choice comes in minute one, the reel is on screen every second, and bonds are digit relationships
Credits run out mid-week	Medium	Day 1 look-dev decides the style before mass generation; batch only approved prompts

7. Step-by-step: the next 24 hours

1. **Approve Higgsfield spending.** Claude was blocked from paid generation in this session (see the note below). Either approve it in this session, or run the Day 1 prompts yourself from `art/HIGGSFIELD_PROMPTS.md` §2–§4.
2. **Pick the style anchor**: generate the 4 "style anchor" variations, choose 1, and save it as `art/lookdev/style_anchor.png`.
3. **NIL key art → Element**, then Vesper, Maeve, Hina and Tamamo.
4. **Unity:** project, URP, WebGL settings; upload an empty build to a private itch page; confirm it loads.
5. **Port** `Core` from the prototype with tests (wheel, reel, patterns, scoring formula from GDD §1.2).
6. **Lock the intro script** (World Bible §8) and generate its storyboard stills, including one still per culture for the ledger montage.
7. End-of-day review: one screenshot-quality mock of a Hyakki battle (Night Parade bridge) made from the approved art. If it doesn't look like a AAA trailer frame, fix the style before anything is mass-produced.

> **Note on Higgsfield in this session:** the 3D Jutsu layouts were built and rendered for free. The first paid image generation (NIL key art) was refused by the session's safety check because it spends credits. Nothing was charged. If you want Claude to run the generations, say so explicitly (and ideally give a credit budget). Otherwise the prompt pack is written so anyone on the team can paste it into Higgsfield directly.

Art status

ASSET	STATUS	NEXT STEP
Art Direction v2 style frames (NIL action, Meridian dawn, Hyakki pier, battle frame)	Submitted; Higgsfield reports "submission unknown"	Reconcile with Higgsfield, then regenerate
Character key art, v2 style (16 characters)	Pending	Generate after the style frames are approved
Meridian era comparison sheet (person / charm / Omen display × 4 eras)	Pending	First Meridian concept task
Environment establishing + battle stage per land (7 lands)	Meridian and Hyakki explored in pass 1	Redo in v2; then the five remaining lands
Enemy sheets (Meridian, Hyakki)	Pending	3-pose sprites per enemy
Intro cinematic shots	1 test shot done	Storyboard stills, then video
Turnarounds and attack key poses for jam heroes	Pending	Needed for rigs

> **Superseded style rules:** the art direction changed to *painted world, inked people* (Ghibli-inspired painted backgrounds + Edgerunners-inspired cel characters and action). Use the prompt grammar in `docs/ART_DIRECTION.md` §6 instead of the style suffix in §1.2 below. Subject descriptions below are still valid.

Paste-ready prompts for character sketches, key art, environments and video cutscenes across every land of the Tally: Meridian (modern capital), Hyakki (Japanese folklore), the River Empire (Chinese folk religion), Śūnyapura (Indian myth and mathematics), Kroton Nova (Greek myth) and the Crossroads Territory (American folklore). Priorities: **[JAM]** = needed for the Nov 13 slice; **[LATER]** = demo and beyond.

1. How to use

1.1 Two routes

- **3D Jutsu** (Claude can drive this from the session): project **"ZERO-SUM OMEN - Look Dev"** has two layouts.
- `CAM_pose` renders `pose_blockout.png` (2:3, full-body three-quarter pose) for every character key art, so the roster shares framing and scale.
- `CAM_street` renders `street_blockout.png` (16:9, deep street with a tower) for city shots.
- Call `generate_angles` with that render plus a prompt below at 2k, and start every character prompt with: *"Use the grey mannequin only as a pose and framing guide; replace it completely."*
- Video: `generate_video` (Seedance 2.5) with an approved still as `start_image`.
- **Higgsfield web app:** image models (Nano Banana Pro, GPT Image 2.6, Seedream, Cinema Studio Image) and video models (Seedance 2.0, Kling 3.0 with a start frame, Cinema Studio Video 3.0). After a hero's key art is approved, **create an Element** and put it in every later prompt for that hero.

1.2 Style suffix (append to every image prompt, unchanged)

> premium anime game key art, 2.5D anime RPG character art, crisp clean lineart, cel shading with painterly soft lighting, high-detail costume design, cinematic rim light, expressive face, consistent anime proportions (about 7 heads tall), rich but controlled palette, ultra high resolution, clean silhouette that reads at small size, no text, no watermark, no logo, no extra limbs, correct hands

1.3 Land style lines (add to environments, VFX and cut-in textures; characters stay anime)

LAND	STYLE LINE
Meridian Undercity	*anime cyber-noir: heavy rain, neon in amber and teal, nixie-tube signage, wet reflections, stacked tenements*
Hyakki (Japan-inspired)	*ukiyo-e woodblock print influence: flat graphic colour fields, bold outlines, stylised Hokusai-like waves and clouds, washi paper texture, indigo, vermilion and gold*
River Empire (China-inspired)	harbor: *gongbi fine-line painting with gold leaf, red lanterns, lacquer and jade, festival neon* · underworld: *ink-wash shan shui, misty monochrome with vermilion seals, rice-paper texture*
Śūnyapura (India-inspired)	*Indian miniature painting and Pattachitra influence: ornate borders, rich mineral pigments (lapis, saffron, peacock green, gold), monsoon light, intricate geometric stepwells and stone observatory instruments*
Kroton Nova (Greece-inspired)	*Aegean light, white marble and deep blue sea, black- and red-figure pottery motifs, mosaic patterns, Greek key borders, bronze*
Crossroads Territory (America-inspired)	*Americana: desert sunset gradients, Route-66 motel neon, pulp western poster lettering style, art-deco casino lights, dust and starry night skies*
The Basilica	*colossal brass clockwork cathedral, monochrome with nixie amber glow, walls of scrolling numbers*

1.4 Rules

- Generate 4 variations, pick 1, then iterate with the Element. Approve the style anchor before mass production.

- Log everything that ships in `docs/AI_DISCLOSURE.md`.
- Cultural review before release (World Bible §10). Deities are never shown as monsters.

2. Style anchor [JAM] (generate first, pick one)

Render: `pose_blockout.png` (2:3).

> Use the grey mannequin only as a pose and framing guide; replace it completely. Style exploration for an anime RPG called ZERO-SUM: OMEN, a world where every person has a glowing two-digit number floating above their head. A young protagonist in a long black coat standing in a rain-soaked neon alley at night, a flickering holographic "NaN" glitch above their head, glowing orange nixie-tube digits drifting in the air; around them, lucky charms from many cultures hang from wires: a horseshoe, a beckoning cat, a string of lemon and green chillies, a blue evil-eye bead, a red paper talisman. [style suffix]

Variants: add one of *(a) "bold graphic shapes, high contrast"* · *(b) "soft painterly storybook light"* · *(c) "ink outlines with brush texture"* · *(d) "glossy splash-art finish with strong bloom"*. The pick becomes `art/lookdev/style_anchor.png`.

3. Characters

Templates (after the key art is approved; use the Element): - **Turnaround:** "Character turnaround sheet of {ELEMENT}: front, three-quarter, side and back views, neutral standing pose, flat light grey background, identical outfit and proportions. [style suffix]" - **Expressions:** "Expression sheet of {ELEMENT}: neutral, smirk, laughing, angry, shocked, sad; head and shoulders; flat background. [style suffix]" - **Battle key poses:** "{ELEMENT} in three sequential attack key poses for 2D game animation: anticipation, strike, follow-through; full body; consistent scale; flat background; motion lines. [style suffix]" - **Ultimate splash:** "Full-screen ultimate cut-in illustration of {ELEMENT}: {ultimate}, extreme dynamic perspective, speed lines, glowing digits bursting outward. 16:9. [style suffix] [land style line]" - **Reactions:** "{ELEMENT} reacting with {emotion}: three small poses, flat background. [style suffix]"

3.1 NIL, the Remainder [JAM]

> Use the grey mannequin only as a pose and framing guide; replace it completely. Full-body character concept of NIL, protagonist of an anime RPG. Androgynous young adult about 19, sharp amber eyes, messy silver-white hair with one glowing nixie-orange streak, a broken holographic "NaN" glyph flickering above the head like a cracked halo. Long asymmetric black actuary's coat with brass ledger clasps and a high collar, fingerless gloves, tall boots, a cracked brass decoder device fused into the RIGHT wrist leaking orange light and floating digits. Right arm extended, fingers spread, a spinning ring of glowing digits 0–9 orbiting the open hand. Rainy neon night, orange and teal rim light, plain dark atmospheric background. [style suffix]

Ultimate: *a fourth nixie tube tears open in the air and every digit pours out of it like a storm.*

3.2 Vesper Sette (7), gunslinger [JAM]

> Use the grey mannequin only as a pose and framing guide; replace it completely. Full-body character concept of Vesper Sette, a gunslinger and former casino croupier. Tall woman in her late 20s, crooked grin, small scar across her lip, black hair with a crimson underlayer in a long braid, red eyes. Crimson long coat over a black croupier's waistcoat and white shirt with rolled sleeves, wide-brim black hat with playing cards in the band, a large revolver with a seven-chamber cylinder engraved 1–7 held forward, faint red glowing "7" motifs. Mix of neon noir and western frontier. [style suffix]

Ultimate: *seven muzzle flashes in a ring around her, each bullet trailing a glowing red 7.*

3.3 Maeve Triskel (3), charm-smith [JAM]

> Use the grey mannequin only as a pose and framing guide; replace it completely. Full-body character concept of Maeve Triskel, a cheerful blacksmith's daughter from a Celtic immigrant quarter of a neon city. Freckled young woman around 20, bright red hair in three braids, green eyes, leather forge apron over rolled-sleeve work clothes, heavy boots, horseshoe-shaped knuckle gauntlets glowing copper-hot, a four-leaf-clover pin on her collar, a forge hammer with a triskele (triple spiral) burned into its head, sparks around her. Warm copper and green palette against a dark forge. [style suffix]

Ultimate: *three spinning red-hot horseshoes orbit her and slam down, each stamping a glowing 3.*

3.4 Hina of the Ninety-Nine (9), tsukumogami [JAM]

> Use the grey mannequin only as a pose and framing guide; replace it completely. Full-body character concept of Hina, a playful tsukumogami spirit born from a 99-year-old Japanese paper umbrella. Small girl-shaped spirit with a short black bob and mischievous golden eyes, a furisode kimono patterned with tiny numbers 1 to 99 in indigo and vermilion, geta sandals, holding a large red-and-white oiled-paper umbrella that has one big eye and a long tongue like a kasa-obake, umbrella ribs glowing faintly, a floating "99" above her head. Paper lanterns and fireflies, night shrine backdrop. [style suffix] Ukiyo-e flat colour accents on the kimono pattern.

Ultimate: *her umbrella spins open into a giant one-eyed moon and a parade of tiny yokai pours out beneath it.*

3.5 Varro Kade, the Ledgerhound [JAM] (Prologue boss)

> Use the grey mannequin only as a pose and framing guide; replace it completely. Full-body boss concept of Varro Kade, a debt collector and bounty hunter in a neon slum. Hulking man, heavy riot-armour trench coat in rust and gunmetal, a hound-skull mask with glowing red eyes, chains of glass debt jars on his belt each holding a floating glowing digit, a massive hooked collection baton, his Omen "61" floating above his head in red. Rain, neon, steam, low angle. [style suffix]

3.6 Tamamo, the Nine-Tailed Auditor [JAM] (Act I boss)

> Use the grey mannequin only as a pose and framing guide; replace it completely. Full-body boss concept of Tamamo, an elegant and dangerous nine-tailed fox spirit from Japanese folklore. Tall, beautiful woman with fox ears, long gold-white hair, sly violet eyes with red eye-liner, layered Heian-style courtly robes in gold, violet and white, nine enormous glowing fox tails fanned behind her, each tail tip holding a floating glowing digit, blue-white foxfire flames drifting around her, a folding fan in one hand. Moonlit palace, ukiyo-e cloud shapes in the background. [style suffix] [Hyakki style line]

3.7 Comptroller Lucan Thale [JAM] (intro narrator; teaser)

> Full-body character concept of Comptroller Lucan Thale, the calm and sympathetic villain. Tall ageless man, swept-back silver hair, immaculate white and brass vestments shaped like a clockwork cathedral, a monocle with a slowly turning gear, gloved hands folded, a steel (not glowing) "50" floating above his head. Before enormous brass gears and a wall of scrolling numbers in cold gold light. [style suffix]

3.8 Later roster and bosses [LATER]

- **Ba Jinling (8), River Empire:** elegant woman in a modern jade-and-gold qipao, eight tiny golden bells in her hair ornaments and anklets, a folding fan whose ribs are abacus rods, smoky violet eyes, red lips; red lanterns and gold-leaf harbor behind. [gongbi line]
- **Bai Si (4), River Empire underworld:** very tall pale man, long white hair bound with black funeral ribbons, white mourning robes with black ink 四 sigils, a huge guandao-style blade hung with four paper talismans, joss paper swirling, four lanterns behind him. [ink-wash line]
- **Shunya (0), Śūnyapura:** young woman astronomer-mathematician, long dark braid with brass astrolabe hairpins, indigo-and-saffron layered clothing with mirror-work embroidery, a large brass astrolabe spinning in her hand like a weapon, palm-leaf manuscripts tied at her hip, ink-stained fingers, a glowing "0" that looks like a full circle of light; stone observatory instruments behind. [Śūnyapura line]
- **Prima of Kroton (2), Kroton Nova:** earnest young paladin, short blonde hair, blue eyes, white-and-gold armour with Greek-key borders, a giant round shield shaped like a sieve set with blue glass, a halo of floating glyphs 2-3-5-7; white marble and Aegean sea behind. [Kroton line]
- **Fibi Leone (Fibonacci), Crossroads:** 18-year-old casino dealer, golden spiral-curled hair, spiral-patterned irises, tailored croupier tailcoat with headset, glowing cards flowing around her in a golden spiral; desert casino neon behind. [Crossroads line]
- **Chancellor Jin Chan, the Golden Toad:** enormous jovial lord robed in gold coins on a three-legged toad throne, coins spilling from his mouth. [gongbi line]
- **Rahu & Ketu, the Eclipse** (cosmic, tragic, awe-inspiring, *not* demonic or grotesque): a vast crowned celestial head devouring a sun's light, and a separate headless serpentine body with a comet's tail, in a star-filled monsoon sky. [Śūnyapura line] *Have a cultural reviewer check before use.*
- **Archon Seventeen:** gaunt, beautiful, severe hierarch in white and bronze, laurel crown of bronze, a staff topped with a sieve-shaped disc, a cold "17" overhead. [Kroton line]
- **The House (Mr. Eighty-Nine):** elegant old croupier in a white suit at a desert crossroads under a single streetlamp at midnight, ouroboros tattoo around his throat, a pocket watch running backwards. [Crossroads line]
- **Keepers (shown with reverence):** Enma as a towering, solemn judge in red robes with a great ledger (Hyakki) · Judge Cui with a giant brush and the Book of Life and Death (River Empire) · Chitragupta as a serene scribe writing on palm leaves by lamplight (Śūnyapura) · the Moirai spinning, measuring and cutting a glowing thread in a cave (Kroton Nova).

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4. Environments

Battle-stage rule: **16:9, empty centre-left floor for 3 heroes, empty right side for the enemy, clear space top-centre for the land's reel object, horizon around 60%.**

4.1 Meridian Undercity (Prologue) [JAM]

- **Establishing** (render `street_blockout.png`): "Anime cyber-noir slum beneath a giant brass cathedral tower, stacked tenements, neon signs showing two-digit numbers, charms from many cultures hanging over doorways (horseshoes, beckoning cats, lemon-and-chilli strings, evil-eye beads, red paper talismans), heavy rain, crowds with small glowing numbers above their heads, a searchlight beam sweeping the alley at dawn. [Meridian line] [style suffix]"
- **Battle stage:** "Wide side-on battle background: a rain-soaked neon alley with a broken drain gate, puddles, a dead neon sign shaped like three nixie tubes at top centre, empty floor space, foreground pipes. [Meridian line] [style suffix]"
- **Naming shrine:** "A cramped black-market shrine, an old jury-rigged terminal of brass dials and ten glowing nixie tubes on an altar, incense smoke, charms from many cultures, a single amber lamp. [style suffix]"

4.2 Hyakki (Act I) [JAM]

- **Establishing:** "A misty Japanese-inspired island town at night under a giant full moon, a huge stylised wave curling around the harbor, a long red bridge with a Night Parade of one hundred yokai crossing it (umbrella spirits, lantern ghosts, kappa, foxes), torii gates climbing a hill, paper lanterns everywhere. [Hyakki line] [style suffix]"

- **Battle stage A (the Night Parade bridge):** "Wide side-on battle background on a red arched bridge at night, rows of paper lanterns, a torii gate at top centre with three large hanging lanterns (the reel), fog over dark water below, distant yokai silhouettes, empty floor space. [Hyakki line] [style suffix]"
- **Battle stage B (Tamamo's foxfire palace):** "Wide side-on battle background inside a moonlit palace hall with sliding shoji doors painted with nine-tailed foxes, blue-white foxfire floating, gold-leaf folding screens, empty floor space. [Hyakki line] [style suffix]"
- **Shrine of the Seven Lucky Gods:** "A small hillside shrine with seven statues of the Seven Lucky Gods, a treasure ship carving, daruma dolls and beckoning cats on the steps, morning mist. [Hyakki line] [style suffix]"

4.3 Later lands [LATER]

- **River Empire:** Bāfā Harbor Lantern Festival over the Luck Exchange (golden abacus reel), and the Ten Courts with Naihe Bridge and endless shelves of ledgers.
- **Śūnyapura:** "a monsoon city built around a colossal stone open-air observatory with giant sundials and astrolabes, a geometric stepwell descending in perfect symmetry, lamps reflecting in rain pools" (reel = three sundial dials).
- **Kroton Nova:** "a white marble island city shaped like a gigantic stone sieve above a deep blue Aegean sea, mosaics of numbers, bronze automata on patrol" (reel = three columns with mosaic numerals).
- **Crossroads Territory:** "a desert crossroads at midnight under one streetlamp, a lone signpost, starry sky; beyond it the casino boomtown of Lucky Strike glowing with art-deco neon, a ghost train crossing the horizon" (reel = a giant slot machine).
- **The Basilica:** clockwork cathedral interior whose walls show every land's original ledger.

5. Enemies [JAM]

- **Debt Hound:** "Lean cyber-dog with a debt-collector's collar, red digit display on its flank, sparking jaw, side view, flat background. [style suffix]"
- **Collector:** "Armoured slum bailiff with a riot shield stamped with a ledger seal and a glowing number overhead, side view. [style suffix]"
- **Noiseling:** "Small glitch creature made of scrambled floating digits and static, cute but unsettling, side view. [style suffix]"
- **Kasa-obake:** "Hopping one-eyed paper umbrella spirit with a long tongue and a single wooden leg, mischievous, side view. [Hyakki line] [style suffix]"
- **Chōchin-obake:** "Floating paper lantern ghost with a torn mouth and glowing eyes, flames inside, side view. [Hyakki line] [style suffix]"
- **Kappa:** "Turtle-shelled river imp with a water-filled dish on its head, webbed hands, cheeky expression, side view. [Hyakki line] [style suffix]"
- **Oni enforcer:** "Red-skinned horned ogre in a debt-collector's haori jacket with an iron club studded with numbers, side view. [Hyakki line] [style suffix]"

6. Intro cinematic (video) [JAM]

Make a still for each shot (same Elements), then animate it as the **start image**. 720p, 16:9.

#	LENGTH	START STILL PROMPT	MOTION PROMPT
1	8 s	Abstract chaos: floods, toppling towers, hail shaped like dice, rendered in ink splashes and digital static	Ink and static churn violently; dice-hail falls; slow push-in
2a	4 s	Three women of Greek myth spinning, measuring and cutting a glowing thread, in red-figure pottery style on black	The thread glows and runs off-frame to the right like a fuse
2b	4 s	A serene scribe writing on palm-leaf pages by lamplight, Indian miniature painting style with ornate border	Script glows on the palm leaves and lifts into the air as numbers
2c	4 s	A judge with a giant brush writing in an enormous Book of Life and Death, ink-wash style	Characters lift off the page and become glowing numbers

#	LENGTH	START STILL PROMPT	MOTION PROMPT
2d	4 s	A towering solemn judge in red robes opening a great ledger as a lantern-lit parade of yokai passes, ukiyo-e woodblock style	Lanterns sway; the ledger's pages flip in the wind
2e	4 s	A hand signing a black book under a lone streetlamp at a desert crossroads at midnight, Americana woodcut style	The ink signature glows red; the streetlamp flickers
3	12 s	A colossal brass clockwork cathedral rising over a modern city; brass chains reaching out to five glowing books and scrolls from different art styles	The chains drag the five ledgers into the cathedral; gears swallow them; its eye opens and a sunrise beam sweeps the world as a number appears above every head
5	15 s	Dawn in a neon slum: crowds with glowing numbers overhead; a tired mother with "01", her small son staring at it	Camera cranes down through rain; numbers tick; the mother's number flickers to 01; the boy grabs her sleeve
6	10 s	Armoured debt collectors with hound masks pushing through the crowd; one hooded figure with a broken "NaN" glitch stays still	Collectors advance in slow motion; the hood lifts to reveal NIL's amber eyes; NaN crackles
7	8 s	NIL's hand reaching toward the mother; a ring of glowing digits spinning around her "01"	Digits spin like a slot reel and lock on "07" with a flash; collectors turn toward NIL
8	12 s	NIL running through neon alleys hung with charms from many cultures, collectors and cyber-dogs behind	Fast anime chase: low tracking, splashing puddles, sliding under pipes, ducking into an amber-lit shrine doorway
10	10 s	Every screen and sign in the city glitching to "REMAINDER DETECTED"; the cathedral's eye glowing red	The glitch spreads screen to screen; numbers above every head scramble; bounty posters with NIL's face flutter down in the rain

Shots 4 (title), 9 (lucky-number choice) and 11 (logo slam) are built in-engine.

7. Ultimates and Link Arts [JAM]

- **Ultimate clips (3–4 s):** start image = the hero's ultimate splash. Motion: *"Explosive anime ultimate, fast camera push, speed lines, glowing digits bursting outward, impact flash, hold."*
- **Lucky Strike (Vesper + Maeve):** still: *"Maeve hurling a red-hot horseshoe through the air while Vesper aims her revolver at it, neon alley"*; motion: *"Vesper shoots the horseshoe mid-air; it shatters into seven glowing ricochets that converge on the target."*
- **Midnight Parade (Hina + Vesper):** still: *"Hina riding her one-eyed umbrella over swinging saloon doors as a parade of ukiyo-e yokai pours through behind her, Vesper tipping her hat"*; motion: *"the yokai stampede across the screen in woodblock style while Vesper fires through the gaps."*
- **Land cut-in bands:** neon-glitch bands (Meridian) and **woodblock-print wave bands** (Hyakki), built in-engine from generated textures.

8. Land-styled reel objects [JAM]

- Meridian: "A dead neon sign shaped like three nixie tubes in a rusted brass frame, front view, flat background."
- Hyakki: "A vermilion torii gate with three large paper lanterns hanging from its beam, each lantern able to show one painted numeral, front view, flat background."

PART IX

Appendix

Writing rules and disclosures.



How the game sounds. Use it for dialogue, item text, UI copy and marketing.

1. Tone

- **Warm noir.** The world is unfair and the jokes are dry, but people are kind to each other. Think rainy city detective story told by someone who still believes in strangers.
- **Wonder before cynicism.** Every land should feel like a place you'd want to visit, even when it's in danger.
- **Stakes are personal.** Big ideas (fate, luck, conservation) always land through one person's number.
- **Age rating target:** Teen. Peril, death off-screen ("settling"), no gore, no sexual content, mild language.

2. Voice rules

1. **Short lines.** Most dialogue lines are under 15 words. Cut adjectives first.
2. **One number habit per character** (Character Bible §12). Don't overuse it: once per scene at most.
3. **Numbers are spoken, not displayed.** Avoid "+15% luck". Say "that one's lucky", "your Omen's rising".
4. **NIL speaks least.** Their silences are written in, as beats.
5. **No exposition dumps.** Lore arrives through objects, jokes and choices, three sentences at most at a time.
6. **Villains get the best arguments.** Thale's lines should make players hesitate.
7. **Cultures are lived, not explained.** Characters mention their customs casually and never stop to define them for the player; the Codex does that.

3. Formatting

- Speaker names in caps in scripts: `VESPER:`
- Omens written as two digits: "Omen 07".
- Lore terms capitalised per the Lexicon (the Basilica, the Ledger, the Rounding).
- Non-English terms in italics on first use in the Codex only, never in dialogue.

4. Sample scene (intro, after the Naming Rite)

> *The terminal sparks. Every tube on the wall flips to orange.* **PRIEST:** That's… not a number, child. **NIL:** It's mine. *(beat)* Is that a problem? *Outside, every screen in the city reads REMAINDER DETECTED.* **PRIEST:** Run.

5. UI and item copy

- Item names are concrete and short: "Beckoning Cat", "Door God", "Rabbit's Foot".
- Item text = rule, then flavour in one line: "+1 fen per strike ending in your digit. *It waves twice for regulars.*"
- Pattern banners in caps: JACKPOT, OMEN OVERWRITE, ZERO-SUM.
- Errors and confirmations speak plainly: "Not enough fen." / "Charm equipped."

6. Cultural care in writing

- Ask a native speaker to review all dialogue and names from Hyakki, the River Empire and Śūnyapura.
- Keepers speak with dignity; no comic relief at their expense.
- No accents rendered phonetically in text.

The Official Unity Game Jam 2026 allows generative AI **only if it is disclosed on the submission page, including how it was used.** Not disclosing disqualifies the entry from prizes. Log every AI-assisted asset that ships, as you make it, and paste the summary into the itch page.

Summary for the submission page (fill in before submitting)

> Generative AI was used in this project as follows: … Everything else (game design, code, animation rigs, motion graphics, editing, music arrangement, writing) was made by the team.

Log

DATE	ASSET	TOOL / MODEL	HOW IT WAS USED	HUMAN EDITS AFTER GENERATION
2026-11-06	Design docs, prototype code	Claude (Anthropic) via Claude Code	Drafted design documents and the browser prototype with the team	Reviewed and directed by the team
2026-11-06	`art/lookdev/*_blockout.png`	Higgsfield 3D Jutsu (Blender scene)	Simple 3D layout renders used as composition guides	— (not shipped)
2026-11-06	`art/concepts/*.jpg` (character key art and environment concepts)	Higgsfield 3D Jutsu "angles" (Seedream V5 Pro), image generated over our own 3D layout renders, from prompts in `art/HIGGSFIELD_PROMPTS.md`	Concept and key art for NIL, Vesper, Maeve, Hina, Tamamo, Varro, Thale; Meridian and Hyakki environments	Concepts only so far; shipped versions will be painted over, layered and rigged by the team
2026-11-06	`art/motion/*.mp4` (intro shot, NIL reveal)	Higgsfield 3D Jutsu video (Seedance 2.5), animated from our generated key art as the start frame	Cinematic pipeline tests for the intro and character reveals	Tests only; final cutscenes will be edited, graded, scored and subtitled by the team